Perfect

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39016257.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Hurt/Comfort, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Let Catra (She-Ra) Say Fuck, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Portal shenanigans, physics - freeform, Dreams vs. Reality

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Part 4 of for Having Wept in the Darkness

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by Lycaonpictus77

Summary

Adora has almost everything she's ever wanted: The perfect girlfriend, the perfect family, the perfect life. The only thing standing in the way of her happiness is the ongoing struggle against the Horde, until she begins having visions that may turn everything she knows on its head. As she begins to question her reality, each new piece of information feels larger than the last—but are any of them real?

Notes

fuck it happy Catradoranniversary

Awakening

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wasn't sure what woke her, the vestiges of some vaguely disturbing dream slipping away as she blinked into wakefulness, warm and comfortable and safe. She took a deep breath to ground herself. The air was cool and clean, heavy with the smell of sleep and—

Catra. She was holding her a little too tight. Adora loosened her arms, pressing an apologetic kiss to the crown of her head. Catra leaned into it, relaxing with a contented sigh that melted into the syrupy purr that meant she was still sleeping.

Adora smiled to herself, watching her for a moment in the pale blue of fading night. She wasn't ready to go back to sleep yet, and, curled on their sides, she had the perfect vantage point to simply drink Catra in.

She was beautiful, soft and vulnerable in a way she so rarely was during her waking hours, her eyes crinkled by the ghost of a smile as she pressed nearer to Adora, nuzzling against her skin. Catra was so… delicate was the wrong word, but there was something in the details of her face, something almost urgent about absorbing and preserving the details. Memorizing the freckles dusting the apple of her cheek, the sweep of her eyelashes, the fur-softened edge of her jaw.

Adora reached up to tuck a lock of hair behind her ear, heart squeezing as Catra's face turned instinctively to follow the warmth of her wrist.

She trilled faintly at the contact, yellow eye cracking open just a sliver to peer up at her. "Mmm, 'dora?"

“Hey,” Adora whispered, pressing another kiss to her forehead. “Go back to sleep.”

“Why’re you up?” asked Catra, a little clearer. She raised her hand to rub her eyes, still half-asleep.

“Just am,” said Adora, when Catra had lowered her hand enough to look back at her. “Don’t worry. Everything’s perfect.”

Catra smiled slyly, craning her neck so their foreheads were resting against each other. “Were you watching me sleep, you big weirdo?”

“Can’t help it,” said Adora, grinning at her. “I woke up and hey, there you were. Have I told you how pretty you are lately?”

Catra’s smile turned to fond exasperation, and she broke eye contact as if it would stop Adora from picking up on the pleased blush just visible under her fur, even in the poor lighting. Adora chased that blush so often and so ardently that she could practically see it with her eyes closed.

“Ugh,” Catra mumbled, though she didn’t pull away. “Get out of my room.”

“Make me,” Adora teased, sliding their noses together, half-nuzzle and half-challenge.

Catra huffed, visibly debating whether it was too early to physically kick Adora out of the bed.

Fortunately, the answer seemed to be yes. She raised her chin instead, and Adora sighed blissfully as their lips met in a slow, lazy kiss.

“Love you,” she whispered as they broke apart, chest warm and full. Catra seemed to be drifting back off to sleep, pressing her nose to Adora’s cheek like she wanted to get closer but wasn’t awake enough to puzzle out how.

"Love you too," she mumbled into the space by Adora's ear. Adora shifted a little, rolling onto her back so that Catra was draped over her like a blanket, and let the sound of her purr soothe her back to her own sleep.

- - -

"Adora! Catra! I'm respecting your boundaries!"

Adora groaned, pressing her face into Catra's hair.

"One of my boundaries is not being woken up!" Catra called back, limbs tightening around her. Her voice cracked a little in the middle, rough with sleep.

Adora reluctantly peeled her eyelids open, squinting around the room. It had been a few hours since she'd drifted back to sleep; it was well after when she would have woken up back home, but it was hard to convince herself to get out of a bed that had Catra in it.

"Yeah but I *knocked!"* said Bow, bursting into the room and beaming at them. Adora groaned again, dropping her head back onto the pillow and trying to blink the sleep from her eyes.

"Bow," she stressed, rubbing her face and addressing the ceiling because his smile was way too bright to handle without breakfast, "we didn't say you could come in."

She looked back at him just in time for him to pull out the pout, crossing his arms defensively over his chest like the overgrown toddler he was. She was *so* going to put him in a headlock for this later.

"You wouldn't have answered if you were busy!" he insisted.

“One of these days I will, and then you’ll *really* be sorry,” Catra muttered into Adora’s shoulder. “What do you even want?”

“They’re gonna stop serving breakfast in like twenty minutes,” said Bow. “You *know* what Adora’s like when she’s hungry.”

“Ugh, I do,” Catra muttered, releasing her hold on Adora to wriggle into a sitting position. Adora whined at the loss of warmth, wrapping her arms around Catra’s neck so she was half-dragged up herself. “We could just raid the kitchens later, you know.”

“I also wanted to talk to you about the party,” he admitted sheepishly.

“Party?” Adora mumbled into Catra’s elbow, squinting one eye open.

“Uh, yeah? Your birthday?”

She frowned to herself. Birthday. Birthday party.

“Man, how late were you guys up?” asked Bow, chuckling.

“Too late,” said Catra, brushing some of Adora’s hair out of her face. “Hey, dumbass. Wake up a little.”

“But I’m *comfy.”*

“You can be comfy once you’ve got your brain turned on. You forgot your own birthday.”

“S’not my birthday,” she yawned, reluctantly pulling her face from Catra’s arm. “... When’s my birthday?”

“It’s next week, dummy,” Catra chuckled. “C’mon, let’s get some food in you.”

“Get some food in *you,”* said Adora, slumping sideways onto the mattress as Catra *abandoned* her. “Nooo, come back.”

"We can nap later," Catra told her severely, pulling the blanket away. "It's your first birthday party, I'm not fucking it up."

"First? Catra, you've been going since she turned like, five," said Bow, snorting.

"It's her first birthday party as *my* girlfriend," she replied haughtily. "The rest don't count."

"You were *there!"*

Adora grumbled to herself as she stood up, grabbing her clothes from the pile by the dresser and getting changed, trying not to sulk. Catra wasn't even looking, arguing with Bow about something.

Stupid Bow.

"Okay, okay," she said, striding over as she tied up her hair. "Beat it, shrimp. Catra's gotta get dressed."

"I am *taller than you,"* he told her, faux-scandalized, but allowed her to shove him bodily out the door, slamming it behind him.

She pressed her forehead against the cool wood, sighing.

"Aw, hangry already?" teased Catra, grabbing her own clothes.

"I just want a little time alone with my super hot girlfriend," said Adora, gesturing at the closed door as if to ask how it had the nerve to interrupt. "Is that so much to ask?"

"It is in Bright Moon," Catra said ruefully as she changed. She made an exaggerated 'thinking' face as she shrugged into her jacket. "Or anywhere, with him and Glimmer around. I keep telling you we should run away together."

Adora rolled her eyes, opening the door for her with a dramatic bow. "Yeah, the Rebellion would *love* that. There's no way they'd come after us immediately."

“Oh, come on,” said Catra, grinning at her. “Do you really think they could catch us?”

“No,” she admitted. “But we’d cave after like, a week. We couldn’t just let them have all the fun without us, right?”

Catra made a show of rolling her eyes. “Yeah, yeah. And I guess we’d miss your party.”

“Right!”

They didn’t quite race to the dining hall, but there was too much jostling and a few too many playful swipes for it to be called even speed-walking, and they were definitely competing to see who could get there first. Adora allowed herself a triumphant shout as she was the first to cross the threshold, seconds before Catra tackled her to the ground.

“You cheated,” she informed Adora. “I refuse to abide by these results. Surrender immediately.”

“I didn’t cheat!” Adora protested, grinning up at her. “It’s not my fault you weren’t paying attention.”

“Uh, it super was. You distracted me by being all pretty and in love with me and shit.”

Adora laughed, pressing a kiss to her chin, the only part of her face within reach while she was pinned by the shoulders. “You’re right, I shouldn’t distract you by having a face. I totally cheated.”

“I’m glad you agree,” said Catra, releasing her and getting to her feet. “Morning, Glim.”

Glimmer raised a hand in greeting, more than used to their antics at this point. “Catra. Adora. You two are up later than usual.”

“You’re not, sleepyhead,” said Catra, plopping into the seat next to her and ruffling her hair. Glimmer squawked, smacking her hand

away. “Bow didn’t wake you up for the party planning committee too, did he?”

“He knows better,” she said darkly, taking a bite of her food.

Adora laughed openly at her murderous expression. Sleepy Glimmer was one of her favorite people, just the right amount of ruthless and adorable. It always reminded her of Catra, though she’d never tell either of them so; she liked all of her limbs attached to her body.

She loaded up a plate of food and took a seat across from them, content to watch their morning bickering unfold.

“Speaking of knowing better, did you present the plan yet?” asked Catra, trying to steal some of Glimmer’s food. Glimmer slapped her fingers away, eyes narrowing.

“Yes. Mom says it’s ‘too dangerous’ and we’re going to get ourselves killed. You know, the usual.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Right, because we haven’t been kicking the Horde’s ass since she let us on the field. What’d your dad say?” she asked, plucking a sausage from Adora’s plate. Adora, who had prepared a small cache of breakfast meats for this very purpose, pushed the dish closer to her. Catra insisted that food tasted better when it was stolen, even if it was something Adora was happy to share in the first place.

“That it’s risky and he’ll only authorize it if we can get another princess on board,” said Glimmer, pouting. “Perfuma is closest but somehow I don’t really see her signing on for an offensive, do you?”

“She can be persuaded,” said Catra, eyes glittering as she looked back at Adora, who instantly sat up a little straighter. “We just need to bring out the big guns.”

“We have guns now?” asked Adora, frowning at her. That seemed like something she should have been briefed on. “How many?

What kind?”

“She means your arms, Adora,” sighed Glimmer.

“Is it ethical to dangle your girlfriend in front of another woman like a carrot?” Bow asked from the doorway. Adora could *hear* his raised eyebrow, so she just kept looking at Catra. It was a much better view, anyway.

“Please. Adora’s mine and she knows it,” said Catra, popping another sausage into her mouth. “Perfuma is more than welcome to eat her heart out.”

“Yeah, her heart. That’s all she wants to–ow!” Glimmer protested as Catra elbowed her in the ribs, smirking at Adora.

Adora grinned back, cheeks warming a little even as Bow made a melodramatic retching noise, sliding into the chair next to her. “She can dangle me wherever she wants,” she assured Bow, relishing in the disgusted face he made. “It’s for the good of the cause, right?”

“Sure,” said Glimmer, flat and sarcastic. “It’s not like we have any other ways to convince her, or other princesses who will be coming to your party in a *week.* Clearly getting Adora to flex in front of Perfuma is the only solution.”

“Sorry for wanting to show off my girlfriend,” said Catra, rolling her eyes despite her genuine smile. “It’s not my fault Perfuma likes them shredded.”

“And you don’t?” Glimmer asked skeptically. “You stare at her arms *constantly.”*

Bow whined slightly, but Adora ignored him, preening as Catra’s eyes skated over her exposed arms and softened when they reached her face.

“I can’t help it, I love her,” said Catra, smiling in a way anyone else would describe as shy, but Adora recognized as coy. They

weren't done punishing Bow for waking them up yet. It didn't stop her from practically melting in her seat at the affection.

"I love you too," she said honestly, with a little sigh of contentment for good measure.

"Ugh, if I'd known you two were going to be this gross I wouldn't have rooted for you," Glimmer muttered as they fluttered their eyelashes dramatically across the table at one another, playing up the googoo eyes as Bow groaned in agony.

"I told you," he said, shaking his head. His mouth was twisted between a smile and a grimace. "I told you it would be insufferable, but did anyone listen?"

"You were biased," said Glimmer, wrinkling her nose at him. "And don't pretend you aren't thrilled with this, you cried for like three hours when they got together. You love it."

"I loved it a lot more before I saw my sister getting—"

"We *told* you to *knock!"* Adora interrupted, blushing.

"It wasn't even that bad, you big baby," said Catra. "We still had all our clothes on and everything."

"La la la la la! I can't hear you!" said Bow, slapping his hands over his ears. "I'm not thinking about this now or ever again!"

"You know your door has a lock, right?" Glimmer asked Catra.

"You know you never *use* my door, right?" she countered. "Like it would stop any of you freaks regardless. He should be grateful we aren't making out on every surface in this fucking castle."

"We could change that," Adora put in helpfully, sticking her tongue out at Bow as he cautiously lowered his hands.

"Please don't," said Glimmer, with a smirk that belied her amusement. "I have to eat on this table."

“All I am asking is for a little *decorum,”* said Bow.

“Ugh, you weren’t like this when—when um—”

“When…?” asked Bow, raising an eyebrow.

Adora scowled at him, wracking her brain. “... I have forgotten the names of every single one of our siblings.”

“What is your *deal* today?” asked Catra, openly laughing at her. Adora put a hand to her head, frowning.

“I’m not—”

Catra’s face was superimposed with an expression of absolute betrayal, heartbreak barely concealed beneath the sudden influx of distrust. A mask held her hair out of her face, sharp metal covering her soft edges.

Adora blinked, and her Catra was back, now looking mildly concerned.

“Adora?” she asked uncertainly. “You good?”

“I’m—yeah,” said Adora, looking around the dining hall. “Yeah, I’m just—I guess I slept worse than I thought.”

“Well, let’s go take a walk or something. Get you some fresh air.”

“Okay,” said Adora, getting to her feet. “Yeah. Some fresh air.”

- - -

“Do you think it’ll ever end?” Catra asked.

Adora blinked, looking over at her and then around them at the gardens. Which they were in, suddenly. She must have really

spaced out. “Huh?”

“The war,” clarified Catra, not making eye contact. “Do you think we’ll even… Are we just going to keep fighting until we die? Is that all there is?”

“Of course not,” Adora said softly, slipping Catra’s hand into hers. “There’re things we’re fighting *for.”*

Catra smiled back, wry and almost exasperated. “You fucking sap,” she accused with no bite, bumping their shoulders together. “You know what I mean.”

“It’s got to end eventually,” said Adora, shrugging. “We’ve been taking so much back since Thaymor. The Horde’s running out of territory, and every victory gives us new land, new recruits, new hope.”

“My plan could… If it works, it could all finally be over. If we can just get a second princess on board, or even more than one—we could end this. For real.”

Adora smiled at Catra, watching the way her eyes traced along the lines of shrubs, the petals of flowers, every leaf and twig under intense scrutiny as she organized her thoughts. She was still so alert to every minute change, tuned into her surroundings like no one else Adora had ever known. It made her want to see the world the way Catra saw it, to pick up on every detail and sense every kernel of potential. To appreciate everything Etheria had to offer them.

“What do you want?” Catra asked finally, looking back at her. “When this is all over, when we win, what do you want to do?”

Adora thought about it for a moment, looking back out at the flowers, trying to see them the way Catra did. They’d been fighting for so long that Adora got swept away in it sometimes, pulled along in other people’s currents, distracted from her goals. But Catra never lost sight of what she was fighting for. What she wanted.

"I wanna unseat the reigning champion of ice-ball," Adora said decisively.

"Adora, it's a team sport. *We're* the reigning champions."

"Yeah, but you're the top scorer. That can't stand," said Adora, grinning at her.

"Oh Adora," said Catra, dripping with condescension. "You'll take *that* title over my dead body."

"That can be arranged," said Adora, capitalizing on the disbelieving snort that elicited to pounce.

Catra squeaked as Adora tackled her, rolling to absorb the impact with her shoulders. They struggled for a few moments, but the element of surprise had given Adora the edge she needed. She bracketed Catra's hips with her knees, grinning victoriously down at her, reveling in Catra's feigned annoyance.

"Alright, Second Place Scorer," said Catra, rolling her eyes. She wriggled experimentally, but Adora's hold was solid. Catra huffed and crossed her arms. "You've caught me unawares. Let the assassination attempt commence."

Adora snickered a little as she leaned down to kiss her, running her hands along Catra's arms to entice her to unwind them.

Catra relented after only a moment's cursory pretense, arms unfolding like the petals of some flower Adora didn't know the name of, but could scent from ten paces off. She wrapped them around Adora's neck, drawing her nearer, until their bodies were almost flush and Adora could feel the moon-warmed grass prickling against her bare forearms.

Her hands skated down Catra's sides, her right settling on a hip to draw her even closer as her left palm flattened against Catra's stomach, feeling her breathing change as the kiss deepened.

She was overcome by a wave of affection, breaking the kiss when her smile grew too wide to continue. Catra laughed breathlessly as Adora instead peppered her face with kisses, nuzzling along her cheekbone and pressing their foreheads together for a moment.

"You're such an idiot," said Catra, pressing back. Her voice was full of the same warmth and love that Adora felt bursting out of her own chest, echoing perfectly.

"Your idiot," Adora agreed, grinning wider. Catra laughed again beneath her, stomach shaking under Adora's hand.

It didn't match the deep, fond laugh she was hearing, though. It was almost trembling, Catra's pulse quick and erratic just under her skin. Adora drew back, opening her eyes to check in, and recoiled like she'd been struck at the sight beneath her.

Catra was laid out on the ground, eyes wild and unfocused, the skin under Adora's hand suddenly slick with blood as her chest heaved in too-short breaths.

"No—what—" Adora gasped, surging instinctively onto the wound, uncomprehending as she fought to apply pressure, to locate the source of the injury at all, to—

"Adora!" said Catra, grabbing her face with both hands.

Adora blinked at her, terrified, short gasping breaths wracking her body. She looked down at her hands, pressed against Catra's stomach where her shirt had ridden up slightly, and—

There was no blood. No wound. Catra wasn't even breathing abnormally, *Adora* was.

"Are you okay? What happened?" asked Catra, rubbing a thumb along her cheek. Adora looked back up at her helplessly. Did she fall asleep somehow? Was that a nightmare?

"I'm—I thought I saw—" she tried, swallowing thickly as she looked back down at Catra's stomach, pulling her shirt a little

higher.

“You’re freaking me out,” said Catra, with a nervous laugh as Adora ran her fingers through her fur. “Any particular reason you jumped on my stomach like it was a live grenade?”

“You were hurt,” Adora said, knowing how lost she sounded. “I… you’re not hurt? You’re okay?”

“I’m okay,” said Catra, frowning up at her, hands still curled around Adora’s face. “I mean, I’m kind of concerned that you’re having a nervous breakdown or something, but I’m not hurt.”

“I honestly might be? I feel like I’m forgetting something,” Adora confessed, looking back down at Catra’s stomach so she wouldn’t have to meet her eyes. “Something important.”

“Did you forget your birthday again already?” asked Catra. There was a strained note to the teasing that made Adora’s heart sink in her chest. She was worrying Catra for nothing, everything was fine.

Everything was perfect.

Chapter End Notes

> hey besties sorry I disappeared for 11 months there. been a bit of a wild time IRL. I now have a She-Ra sideblog, mostly for cataloguing images but also for deep lore cuts & theorizing, if you were into my notes on my main. If nothing else it's good reference material lol.
>
> still editing the rest of this monstrosity but I'm very very excited to get to the Good Stuff so I hope you can all hang in there a little longer!

Party

Chapter Notes

> hi gang i drew some gay little outfits for the gals. ik i'm not one for clothing descriptions so you can interpret 'em however you want, but it's how i draw 'em in my gay little thumbnails so it's gay little canon. i did also go a little off the rails breaking them down so please don't feel obligated to read the heaps o' shit i wrote under it, i just have Problems Disease & like it when other artists do that

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“There you are! Are you ready?” asked Glimmer, practically bouncing as she approached them.

Adora blinked, looking around the garden. They were back at the door to the castle—she must have spaced out again. Maybe she *did* need to get more sleep. Clearly whatever nightmare she’d had last night had affected her more than she’d thought.

“Ready for what?” she asked, hesitant as Catra bounded up the short flight of stairs to Glimmer’s side, towing Adora behind her.

“Your dads just got here!” said Glimmer, rolling her eyes. “We have to go rescue Bow, Lance brought the baby pictures.”

Adora felt the blood drain from her face. “Oh no.”

“Oh *fuck* yes,” said Catra with a wicked grin.

“Catra, no! We’re rescuing him!” said Glimmer, though she looked torn.

“You’ve never seen baby-Adora,” said Catra. Her eyes gleamed, and she tugged against Adora’s hand as she strained to carry on down the hallway. Adora dug her heels resolutely into the floor.

"She was like forty percent eyeball, it was incredible. She looked like a freak."

Glimmer lost the battle against her smile, turning to Adora with a speculative smirk.

"Glimmer," Adora pleaded. "I *know* your parents have baby pictures somewhere."

"I was an *adorable* baby, thank you," said Glimmer, sniffing imperiously. "Your threats are nothing to me."

"What are they even *doing* here?" Adora groaned, burying her face in the hand that wasn't holding Catra's. "The party's not for a *week."*

"What?" asked Glimmer. Adora peeked out from between her fingers, frowning at the expression on her face.

"What?" she echoed. "It's next week, isn't it?"

"Adora, your party's in like two hours," said Glimmer, slow and a little concerned.

Adora dropped her hand, looking between them. Catra looked confused, staring at Glimmer like something didn't make sense, but not arguing. They didn't *seem* like they were messing with her, but—

But that was impossible. It had been a week away less than an hour ago.

The nagging feeling of forgetting something important crawled once again up her spine, scratching at the back of her mind.

Her vision burst into a field of blinding white light, blotting out the hallway. She recoiled, keeping Catra's hand clutched tight as she threw up an arm to shield her eyes.

Balance must be restored.

Etheria must seek a hero.

You must let go.

"Adora!" said Catra, squeezing her hand.

Adora opened her eyes. She was half-crouched in the hallway, arm raised defensively to ward against nothing.

"Adora, seriously, what's going on?" asked Catra.

"I… you didn't see that?"

"See *what?"*

"That light! There was like a really bright light!" said Adora, gesturing broadly at the space it had been. "It was like—purple, and white, and—and spreading."

"All I saw was you freaking out," said Catra, frowning hard. "Are you going to be okay for the party? Bow and Glimmer can come up with some excuse, it's not a big—"

"Glimmer! Where's Glimmer?" Adora interrupted, snapping to her full height and looking around wildly. "She was right here—"

"They're meeting us there! What's going *on* with you?"

"She was here like a *second* ago Catra, I… she *was."*

"Okay, forget the party. We're taking you to the medbay." Catra grabbed her hand, towing her down the hallway until Adora dug in her heels.

"No, it's—something's *wrong.* I don't need to go to the medbay, I need—we need to figure out what's going on!"

"I know you were excited about the party but we can just reschedule—"

"You're not *listening,"* Adora snapped. Catra dropped her hand, visibly hurt, and Adora cringed. "Sorry. I'm sorry. I just… it's not about the party, okay?"

"So what is it about?" asked Catra, a little defensively.

"I just have this *feeling.* Like something isn't how it's supposed to be, like there's something *wrong.* But I can't remember what it is."

Catra was quiet for a moment, watching her. Considering what she was saying. "Like when you're having a nightmare and you can't figure out what's going to happen? Just like, looming ominous dread?" she asked.

"Exactly," said Adora, shoulders slumping with relief. "It's exactly like that. Do you feel it, too?"

"I…" Catra's eyebrows drew together, like she was thinking about something deeply upsetting, and Adora instinctively took her hand again, rubbing a thumb against her knuckles in a silent show of support. "I don't know. I do feel like I'm forgetting something, but…"

"It doesn't feel wrong?" Adora checked.

"No," said Catra, not meeting her eyes. "I don't know. I feel… happy. I'm happy with you."

"I'm happy with you too," said Adora, smiling faintly. There had been something else—something besides the looming sense of foreboding. Something had… happened? But it couldn't matter that much. Not more than Catra's happiness. "Maybe I'm just catastrophizing again. If you feel it too but it isn't bad, I'm probably just making a big deal out of nothing."

They must have been closer than she'd realized, because the party was just through the next room, doors thrown open and conversations bubbling out. Music was playing from somewhere, light was shining through the round, ornately framed windows,

and tables were laid out against the wall, fencing the guests in with Bright Moon-atypical straight lines—though the spread of food laid out on them was more than enough to soften their edges. She spotted her dads by one of the windows, on the exact opposite side of the room.

Adora sighed, then straightened up. No point in going around when they could face this head-on.

She waded through the crowd of her siblings, elbowing them pointedly as they laughed at her efforts. She wasn't the youngest, but apparently a few months' difference wasn't enough to differentiate her from Bow's status of Designated Baby, at least not in his absence. Catra was laughing too, fingers hooked into the back of Adora's baldric like they would be separated otherwise, the back of her knuckles pressing against the notches in Adora's spine whenever she jabbed at another guest.

"There's our birthday girl!" Lance cheered, breaking out into a smile as she finally emerged from the throng. "And our future daughter-in-law?"

"Dad," Adora groaned, covering her face with one hand and taking Catra's in the other. She couldn't quite smother a goofy grin. They hadn't had a chance to visit home since she and Catra started dating, which she was mostly grateful for—but part of her was bursting with joy, and even if they teased her, she wanted to share that with her family. She could barely believe they were together, and it filled her with a dizzying pride and affection that she was eager to have affirmed.

A moth fluttered in her face, startling her. Catra snatched it out of the air, grimacing as its wings got gross moth-powder on her fur.

"Ew," she muttered, wiping it on Adora's shirt.

"Hey!" Adora protested, laughing.

"Oh, right. You're welcome for defending you," said Catra.

“From a moth?”

“Well, what if it had been poisonous or something? What if assassins had infiltrated the party?”

“I believe you mean venomous, dear,” George put in helpfully.

“Ah, crap, I do. What if it were venomous, Adora? You could have *died.”*

“Then you shouldn’t be smearing it all over my shirt,” said Adora, grinning at her.

“Shhh. Lance wants to talk now.”

“How did you *know?”* asked Lance, practically vibrating with the effort it took to contain himself. “You see, I always said I liked her. From that very first day they brought her back home. Why it feels like just yesterday we were—”

“Your point, dear,” said George, smiling indulgently.

“Of course. Well! We’re very excited about this, obviously,” said Lance, gesturing from Catra’s arm at Adora’s waist to hers slung over Catra’s shoulder. “We just wanted to touch base and make sure you were being responsible, you know—”

“Dad,” Adora interrupted immediately. She could feel herself blush, cheeks heating in embarrassment as Catra didn’t even try to muffle her cackling.

“On the battlefield, obviously,” George finished for his husband, all but smirking at her. They were definitely doing this on purpose. Parents were agonizing. “It’s easy to get distracted, caught in the thrall of young love and all.”

Adora’s blush grew worse as she pointedly avoided their smug little smiles, staring determinedly at one of the refreshment tables.

She did a double take when she realized they were the only ones in the room, the rest of her family having made an uncharacteristically silent exit.

Her eyebrows knitted together as she stared at the untouched food, confusion quickly giving way to anxiety. Would they leave without taking any snacks? Without heckling her a little on the way out?

There was no *way* they all could have left without her noticing.

"Adora?" asked Catra, obviously concerned. Adora glanced at her, but her gaze went back to the empty refreshment table as if drawn by a magnet, unable to leave it alone.

"Adora," said Catra, meeting her eyes. The concern had solidified into *worry,* tinged with something almost like fear. Her arm slid from around Adora's waist, taking the hand that was slung over her own shoulders instead as she turned to face her.

"Something's wrong," said Adora. Breathing was starting to be an issue, her lungs straining against some invisible pressure. She pulled Catra closer and wrapped her up in her arms, burying her face against Catra's shoulder in an effort to force deeper breaths.

"What is it?" asked Catra, voice strained. She clutched Adora back just as tightly with one arm, waving off a fretting George and Lance. Adora couldn't see her face, but she could just *picture* the fake smile, fangs hidden carefully away to keep them at ease.

Adora wasn't at ease. Adora felt like she was losing her mind.

"Something's wrong," she repeated urgently, drawing back to look Catra in the eye. "I keep—we're jumping around, in time and around the castle, and—and I keep seeing—something's *wrong,* Catra."

"Nothing's wrong," said Catra, just shy of forceful. She looked away, ears angled back, tail beginning to flick from side to side in

agitation. “It’s—we’ve just been stressed, lately. It doesn’t matter. Let’s just enjoy the party, okay? Everything is—nothing’s wrong.”

Adora swallowed. “Everything is perfect,” she said carefully, half to herself. Catra twitched under her hands, still avoiding Adora’s eyes. “So what are—”

“Mara, dearie!”

Adora broke off mid-sentence, blinking down at Razz as she approached, happily munching on a plate of mini-tarts. Her broom had a party hat perched on the handle, like it was a guest as well.

“Razz,” said Adora, slowly. “Razz, what’s going on?”

“The same old story, dearie,” said Razz, sighing a little as she shook her head and popped a loose berry in her mouth. “So many threads tangled up in themselves, making a mess.”

“Threads? What?” asked Adora.

“It’s just like the woods, you know,” said Razz, looking to Catra, who was unusually stiff at Adora’s side. Adora looked at her too, confused. “There are so many trails to take you to your destination, but if a road breaks them up, how can the forest help you get there?”

“You’re not making any sense,” said Catra. Flat. Toneless.

“A road is the easiest way to travel,” said Razz. “But roads end, and you won’t like where this one leads.”

“Catra doesn’t take the roads,” said Adora, a little uneasily. This felt like a metaphor, or some kind of literary reference she wasn’t well-read enough to understand. But Razz was always so literal, even if she got confused now and then.

“Of course not, dearie! She thinks they’re too slow!” said Razz, laughing. “And she’s right!”

“So, what,” growled Catra, her tail lashing back and forth as she grew more agitated, “you want me to be a trailblazer? Is that it? Throw everything away so I can get lost in the fucking woods?”

“Oh dearie,” said Razz, softening. She reached up, stretching on her tiptoes to touch Catra’s face, and patted her cheek with a gentleness that Catra visibly melted into. “Of course not. Trails are only made because someone has walked them before.”

Catra’s tail stopped lashing, and her shoulders stiffened even further.

“This has happened before?” she asked quietly.

“What has?” asked Adora. Catra leaned into her side, but her eyes stayed fixed on Razz.

“Where—where did the road lead?” asked Catra. “Before?”

“Same place as every road, dearie,” said Razz, quiet and uncharacteristically morose.

Catra turned, burying her face in Adora’s neck. Automatically, Adora wrapped her arm back around her waist, pulling Catra close against her side.

“What are you talking about?” asked Adora, desperately confused. “Do you—do you know what’s happening to me? Is—is this—those things I’ve been seeing. Are they real?”

Razz looked up at her, solemn eyes magnified by her glasses, and turned back to the party.

The room was completely empty, bare of furniture and her overbearing fathers alike. Even the windows were gone.

“What?” Adora whispered, tightening her arm around Catra.

“There’s still time,” said Razz. “You can still save them.”

“They—what are you talking about?” asked Adora, throat tight around the words. “Everyone—they’re just—they went to another room or something, what are you—”

“They’re gone,” said Catra, face still pressed against Adora. “They disappeared. No one remembers when they go.”

“Catra?” asked Adora, trying to guide her back enough to meet her eyes.

“They’re gone, Adora. I’m sorry.”

Catra drew back, grave and trembling, and Adora could see the sincerity on her face, the pain she wasn’t even trying to mask.

She tried to remember her family, tried to call up an image of George, or Lance, or *anybody.* If no one remembered, she shouldn’t remember either, right?

But she could see them all so clearly.

Her *family.*

Was *that* real? Or was it those twisted shades in the corner of her mind, the things she was seeing, the nightmares—memories—that were fighting to come back to her…?

“They…” Adora started, pausing to clear her throat when her voice came out wet and broken. “We can still save them?”

“Yes, dearie,” Razz assured her, gently. “You just have to go back to the beginning.”

“The beginning of what?” asked Adora, a little desperately. “What can I do?”

“You need to find the sword,” said Razz. Catra flinched violently in Adora’s arms.

“Sword? What sword?”

“You need to remember,” said Razz, looking at Catra now. Catra shook her head, burying her face back in Adora’s neck.

“Catra,” Adora murmured, laying her cheek against Catra’s hair. She pressed a kiss to the back of her ear, tried to take deep enough breaths to actually process her scent, to help herself calm down. “It’s okay. We can fix this.”

Catra flinched again, screwing up her face and baring her teeth defensively where they were pressed against Adora’s throat. With anyone else, it would have been a death threat, but Adora knew the nuances of Catra’s snarls. Sincere, performative, disgusted—and afraid. Catra was terrified right now.

“Razz, I don’t understand. What are we—” Adora started, cutting off with a gasp as she looked up to find an expanse of pure, blinding white where the room had been. Razz smiled at her from the edge of the abyss.

“It will be alright, dearie. You don’t need to understand. You just need to remember.”

- - -

“Come on,” said Catra, pulling back from Adora once again. Something was still wrong, not just witht the world but with *Catra* . She wouldn’t meet Adora’s eyes anymore. She grabbed her by the wrist, towing her down the halls of Castle Bright Moon, heedless of the white and purple cracks spiderwebbing across the floor, the walls, the ceiling. Adora stumbled to keep up with her, heart racing.

“We have to find Bow,” she managed. “A-and Glimmer. They weren’t at the party. Maybe they’re still—”

“We have to get to Entrapta,” said Catra. Her voice was emotionless again, brusque and businesslike, the fear she’d been emanating so strongly conspicuously absent.

“We can’t just leave them,” said Adora. She didn’t stop running, and neither did Catra.

“Why not? You left *me.”*

“What?”

“You *left* me!” Catra hissed, whirling on her. She threw Adora’s hand away like it hurt to hold, fur bristling, and Adora felt like her chest was being torn open by the look on her face. “We said—we *promised* we’d look out for each other, and you—you just *left.”*

“I don’t understand,” Adora said, swallowing her desperation and hurt as best she could. “Catra, what are you talking about?”

“Of course you didn’t remember that part,” she fumed, ears pinning back. “What *do* you remember? What have you seen?”

“I’m—I—”

Catra, raking Adora’s back with her claws as the sounds of a battle filter over water.

Catra, hiding behind a metal crate in a metal hallway as a child, bruised and crying.

Catra, struggling against magical restraints as a shadowy figure wearing a crown approaches her, and Adora is being held back by Shadow W—

Adora slammed her eyes shut, shaking her head viciously.

“They’re not real,” she insisted—pleaded. *“She* isn’t real. We—we grew up here. My dads found me, and–and Razz found you—”

“How did we get together?” Catra demanded. “How did we even—what did you do yesterday?”

Adora shook her head again, pressing her hands to her temples.

"If Bow and Glimmer remembered, they'll meet us there," said Catra, her hands gentle where her voice was harsh. She laced her fingers with Adora's, tugging them loose. "We don't—we don't have to remember. We know something is wrong, and that's enough."

"Razz said—"

"*Fuck* what Razz said," Catra snapped. She looked around the hallway, as if expecting it to crumble into that blank abyss from the force of her voice. "We're together. I don't know—It doesn't *matter* if the shit we're seeing is real. This is real, right now, and we're together, so… we'll look out for each other. Like we've always done. Okay?"

"Okay," said Adora, swallowing. "We need to find Entrapta?"

"She knows about portals," said Catra. "Or at least, she did in one of those freaky visions I had."

"Portals?" Adora repeated, alarmed.

"Portals," said Catra. Her face was grim, but at least she was meeting Adora's eyes again. "I think we went through one? Or something? I don't know, it's like trying to remember a dream. And I don't want—we don't need to know."

"What if we do?" asked Adora.

The walls began to crumble around them, a strange wind sucking pieces of plaster into the formless white. She stepped closer to Catra, reaching for her, clinging to her when the move was reciprocated.

"It doesn't matter," Catra said again, voice thin and desperate, curling into Adora's chest so she could tuck under her chin.

The floor disappeared beneath them, and they clutched each other tight as they fell.

Chapter End Notes

i dithered on whether this should be combined with chapter three bc chapter four is Ridiculously long at this point (especially comparatively), but in the end the cliffhangers hit better like this. remember, as bad as this feels, next chapter will hurt so much more ♥

(but also remember that everything is going to be okay, i prommy)

Confession

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Oh, hello! Do I know you?”

Adora, hunched protectively over Catra, squinted one eye open, slow and cautious. She could barely distinguish Entrapta’s silhouette against the light of her monitors, but the pigtails and voice were enough. A crowd of robots surrounded her, metal joints creaking as their heads swiveled backwards.

“Yes,” said Catra, fingers curling around Adora’s arm as they slowly straightened up. “Or, you used to. It’s Catra and Adora.”

“Wonderful to remake your acquaintance!” said Entrapta, beaming at them. “Which is which?”

Catra sighed, loud and aggrieved.

“I’m Adora, she’s Catra,” said Adora, with a pointless little wave that Entrapta immediately mirrored with a lock of hair, already leaning in to inspect them.

“Are you here because of the unstable portal warping and consuming our reality?” asked Entrapta, scanning them with some kind of weird-looking instrument and typing measurements into her computer with some free hair.

“You remember the portal?” Catra blurted out.

“Oh, remember?” asked Entrapta, tilting her head. She reached for Catra’s necklace with one of her non-hair hands, eyes bright and curious, but Catra slapped it away. “I suppose I don’t. But I’ve certainly noticed the evidence. Is that a data crystal?”

"No," said Catra, narrowing her eyes. She closed her hand over it protectively, irritated with the sudden contact. "And it's mine. Paws off. You said you noticed evidence. What have you seen?"

Entrapta lit up, her hair lifting her several feet higher as she pulled up a series of numbers. "Nothing!" she all but sang, gesturing at a particular column with far too much enthusiasm.

"Nothing?" Adora repeated warily. Why would she be so excited to have no evidence?

"Yes, look," said Entrapta, jabbing her hand at the column again, impatient and expectant. "Even in binary experiments, every result is illogical."

"We can't read your dumb numbers," said Catra, glaring at the column as if she could intimidate it into sharing its secrets.

Entrapta hummed unhappily.

"Well… Hm. According to my research, people find analogies useful for understanding topics which are too complex for them to initially grasp. A binary would be… ah! Well, you have heterochromia—that's eyes which are different colors—so if I asked you to pick an eye it would either be yellow, or blue. Do you understand?"

Catra was bristling at the perceived condescension, so Adora hurried to say, "Yes."

"In my experiments, the results are not abiding by the natural laws of our universe. Sometimes the eye they pick is blue or yellow, but sometimes it's green, or even purple, or sometimes it isn't an eye at all. Sometimes the experiment itself vanishes and only my record of it remains, not even a memory. It's absolutely fascinating!" said Entrapta, gaining enthusiasm as she spoke until she was beaming up at her graphs.

"One equals X, only X doesn't equal one, but it's not *not*- one—X just *isn't.* You see? Variables have been removed completely from

my awareness and my equipment's, mid-experiment, and there are very few phenomena which could manage that."

"Okay," Adora said slowly. "So you noticed the whole portal-warping-reality thing. How do we *stop* it?"

Entrapta stared at her for a moment, blinking, apparently not having considered that yet. "Well, there has to be a power source. Portals *should* be hypercatenoids, either between multiply connected spacetimes or an intrauniverse—well, topologically it would be a 'handle', but I imagine you're more familiar with the term 'wormhole'—"

"Should be," Catra repeated. "But this one's not? Use *small* words."

"Not according to my observations! Instead of a hypercatenoid it's more of a… four-dimensional *hole* . Here, I can show you a diagram if I suppress a dimension…"

She turned to her machines, typing rapidly. Two squares, one red and one blue, appeared on the screen, layered like bread in a sandwich with no filling. As Adora watched, a tube stretched from one to the other, its insides a swirling, placid purple.

"Healthy inter-universe portal," said Entrapta, a little slowly, as if speaking to a child. She typed another series of keys with her hair, still watching their reactions, and the tube was abruptly cut, halfway between the squares.

"Unhealthy inter-universe portal," said Entrapta. A pulsing white dot floated in the open space between the two squares, the blue field floating unaffected above it as a restored square, while the red one looked like a sheet of paper with a hole punched through.

The red began leaking from the hole, uncomfortably fluid, and Adora took an involuntary step back.

Catra, staring up at her with wild eyes, a hole in her abdomen pouring blood—

"So that's the power source?" asked Catra, jabbing at the white dot with a free claw.

"Yep! I've substituted a point of light here, but it will need to be something that can both store and generate tremendous amounts of energy. Almost certainly First Ones' tech, as to my knowledge no modern equipment would be capable of even a fraction of the power required, and the integration of magic would be the only—"

"Storing magic energy?" Adora interrupted. "Like, princess magic? Like a runestone?"

"It could be!" Entrapta said brightly. "It's statistically probable, even!"

"The runestones… are connected to each other," said Catra, eyebrows knitting together, like she was remembering something half-forgotten. "They're all connected to each other and… the planet's power grid. In a delicate balance."

"The planet's what now?" asked Adora, staring at her. "No, sorry, it doesn't matter. If they're all connected then we just need to find one, right? Any runestone?"

Maybe they could actually do this. Get back to Bright Moon or… one of the other kingdoms, now. Fix whatever it was that needed fixing on the runestone and restore… balance…

She curled around a scream, breathing heavily as she came awake, Catra jolting from her position at Adora's feet and turning to her with clear alarm and a question on her lips—

Those same lips, pressed against hers as they both fought back smiles, the shifting light of the Whispering Woods dancing around them—

Fighting someone she couldn't see, stumbling on feet that felt too big, too unwieldy, a sword clenched in one fist—

A sword.

Adora gasped, staggering back as the full weight of her memories slammed into her like a tank, almost knocking one of Entrapta's bots over in her haste to escape her own mind.

What had she done?

What had she *done?*

"*If* that's the power source for the portal, yes," Entrapta affirmed, completely ignorant of Adora's reality ripping itself apart as her memories reasserted themselves, "but…"

Catra rushed to Adora's side, laying a stabilizing hand on her elbow, looking at her with so much concern it *hurt,* the guilt writhing dark and accusing in her stomach.

"But what?" Catra asked Entrapta, glancing back over her shoulder as she tried to gather Adora together, to clasp her shaking hands.

"Portals are gateways that connect one area of space to another," said Entrapta, typing something into her machine. "The only way to turn it off is from the inside."

The diagram of the red and blue squares began to move again, an icon of a person appearing beside the white dot and picking it up. Instantly, the red flowed back together into a smooth plane, rippling like the surface of a pond, the white dot pulled with it.

The person stayed behind.

"The only way to turn it off is from the inside," she repeated, finally turning to look at them. "But whomever shuts it down will be trapped between dimensions. We can send one of my bots if we hurry, but I'll need time to program the—"

Adora's blood was roaring in her ears, her heaving breath almost deafening as she tried to process *that* on top of everything. Catra's hands were still on hers, gentle, stabilizing, but they felt like brands against her skin, marking her for every stolen moment, every touch given and received that Catra *didn't want*—

She snatched her hands away, swallowed hard as the shock and confusion on Catra's face became tinged with hurt, tried desperately to focus on what Entrapta was saying.

"The problem is, things seem to be accelerating exponentially. If we're going to do this I'd need to have started coding almost… two weeks ago," Entrapta was saying, frowning up at her monitors as her hair flew over the keyboard. "And that's *if* the rate remains stable. I think… oh."

She turned to look at Adora, growing still. Her eyes tightened around the corners with some unnamable emotion, and with both her and Catra's gaze on her Adora felt like she was crawling out of her skin.

"It's your sword," said Entrapta, sagging slightly. Catra flinched violently away from both of them, ears going flat against her head. "I remember now. The portal is keyed into you, the anomalies are following you. We don't have much time."

"Wait, *following* me?" Adora asked, looking around for the flashes of white and purple, for the encroaching void of nonbeing. "I—I brought it here? It's…this is my fault?"

"Not at all!" said Entrapta. "That would suggest you caused it, or had a responsibility to prevent it, but you have as much control over it as you do over other basic scientific phenomena. You could no more stop the process than prevent a current from traveling through a completed circuit."

"This can't be happening," said Adora, burying her face in her hands. "I… We should have had more time, this can't—"

“There is no more time,” said Entrapta, her voice fainter than Adora had ever heard it. Adora looked back up at her, gasping as she realized she could see the light of the monitor through Entrapta’s body.

“No!” she yelled, lunging forward to grab her, but her hands passed right through Entrapta’s arms.

“You need to remove the sword from the inside,” said Entrapta, with a brave, trembling smile. How could she be trying to reassure Adora right now? After this? After *everything?* Why did people keep giving her second chances when all she ever did was let them down? “It’s powering the portal. Removing it is the only way to stop this. If you don’t, our dimension will cease to exist.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora choked out. “Entrapta, I didn’t mean for this to happen, I’m sorry—”

“It’s alright,” said Entrapta, smile trembling a little harder. “It was nice to see you again. Both of you. Thank you for being friends with me.”

“No! Entrapta!” Adora yelled again, as Entrapta continued to fade. The light from her monitors pulsed brighter, and brighter, and—

They were standing in the Whispering Woods.

“Fuck!” Adora yelled, whirling on the nearest tree and punching it hard enough to dent the bark. “She was *right there—”*

“Adora,” said Catra, quiet and serious. Adora stilled, hand still balled up in a fist against the bole of the tree.

“Adora, look at me.”

She couldn’t. She turned her head anyway, barely able to see Catra in her peripherals, but at least they wouldn’t make eye contact. Catra would take one look at her and just *know.*

"You remember," Catra accused, wrapping her arms around herself. Adora wanted to replace them with her own, to offer her comfort and protection and assurances, but there were some boundaries she wasn't allowed to cross, not until she explained everything that was going on.

"Yes," she admitted, swallowing thick and slow against the knot of guilt and longing in her throat. She dropped her arm, shoulders sagging, knuckles still throbbing from the impact.

"Everything?" demanded Catra.

"Yes," said Adora. "You… you were right. I left you. I tried to take you with me, but I didn't try *hard* enough. You pulled away and I just… let you go."

Catra didn't say anything, her face angled away from Adora, but the glint of unshed tears in her eyes was unmistakable.

"I'm sorry," said Adora, squeezing her eyes shut. "I'm so sorry, Catra. I should have fought for you—fought *harder* for you. You've always been worth fighting for, but I just couldn't… I *wouldn't* let myself think of it like that."

"Like what?" asked Catra, her voice quiet and trembling. She had never sounded so small, not even when they were children. Catra was brash and aggressive and larger than life; she should never be made less than she was. Adora had believed—had *known* that she loved Catra, before she recovered her memories, but with the complete picture laid out in front of her…

That Catra was only a shade of the real thing. A projected shadow puppet, flat and dull against the vibrant, fathomless original. Her strength and courage, her waspish wit, the ferocity with which she defended the few things she cared about. Somehow growing up in the woods had made her *less* wild, the jagged, uncomfortable edges of her being sanded down until she was smoothed over, a perfectly presentable version of herself.

Was that Adora's fault, too? Did some twisted, untouched corner of her mind *want* that declawed version of Catra? Or was it a natural consequence of their relatively peaceful upbringing? Or the portal reality itself? After all, Adora too had been a pale and palatable imitation, her innumerable failures washed away in a haze of bliss and ignorance.

"Like I was leaving you at all," said Adora, tilting her head back to stare at the sky. Strange lights were dancing there, familiar in a way she didn't initially understand. Stars. "I thought I was just doing my duty, fighting to protect Etheria, and *you* were the one who left *me,* because you didn't come when I asked. But that was —that was stupid."

She could feel Catra looking at her, but she didn't look up. She couldn't bear to meet those mismatched eyes and see the pain and anger she had grown so used to over the course of the war. Or the fresh rage, the fresh betrayal she knew she'd find when Catra realized what Adora had done to her now.

"I didn't do it right," she went on, fighting the shake in her voice. "I… I made it sound like it was your fault for not leaving earlier, like you were just an afterthought to me. I treated you like some… some *object* that I had to protect, with no mind of your own. I didn't even consider how smart you are, how much more observant than I am—of course you would have realized. And I didn't ask why, not really—You said we had each other, but I didn't —"

"Stop," Catra interrupted, hoarse and quiet. "I don't want to hear this. I don't—I don't want to remember."

"Catra, you have a right to know—"

"I don't *want* to know!" she exploded, rounding on Adora. "Every flash I see is worse than the last. I'm miserable, and angry, and scared, and *alone.* Even when you were with me, I always felt alone. I can't go back to that, Adora. I can't fucking live like that. Please don't make me live like that."

“Catra…” said Adora, trailing off as she realized she had no idea what to say.

Catra had lived through so many terrible things, had borne so much abuse and pain and abandonment. How could Adora ask her to subject herself to those memories? Her ostracization by their peers, Shadow Weaver’s constant criticism and impossible challenges, the emotional and physical violence associated with every person in her life but Adora—until Adora abandoned her, too. Hurt her, too.

The disbelief and mounting resentment on Catra’s face as her battered form is swallowed in the dust of Thaymor, not quite succeeding in hiding the pain.

The resignation as she sags into Scorpia’s arms in the ocean by the Sea Gate, not even struggling against the tide. Her expression too far away to make out as Adora is embraced by the replacement friends who had attacked Catra without hesitation.

Slamming Catra into the cliff face with her back, an ominous creak just audible over the sound of crumbling stone that might have been her ribs. Catra’s breath leaving her with a muffled sound of pain as she struggles to keep her hold on She-Ra against the onslaught.

“What if we just stayed?” asked Catra, ears flat against her head. “Here? Together?”

“I—we can’t,” said Adora. “We’ll… We won’t *exist* any more.”

“So what?” Catra asked roughly, voice breaking a little. She bared her teeth at the display of her own vulnerability, pivoting so her back was to Adora. “I’d—if you asked me to, I would stay. I don’t *care* what happened in the real world. I’m… I love you, okay?”

Adora didn’t know if she wanted to laugh or cry. Of course it was only here, *now,* that Catra could return her feelings. In this world that was practically built around their desires. Catra got

everything she'd ever wanted—a home, a family, stability and respect and recognition—and Adora…

Adora got Catra.

She swallowed thickly. Forget laughing or crying; she was going to be sick.

"I'm so sorry, Catra," she said, voice low and shaking as she squeezed her eyes shut. "I didn't—I didn't mean to—I would never want—"

"Stop," Catra snapped, tail lashing and shoulders hunching as she curled away from Adora, like she could shield herself from reality. "Shut up. I don't want to hear it."

"Please," said Adora, reaching out to touch her elbow. Catra jerked away from her. "Please, Catra, I was never going to say anything, I swear. We can just pretend like—"

"Like *what,* Adora?" Catra demanded, whirling around to face her. Her eyes were brimming with tears. Adora's heart felt like it was being wrung out, blood squeezed free like water from a towel, staining her hands. "Like none of this ever happened? We were—we were *happy."*

Her voice broke again, and she took a moment to rake a hand through her hair.

"We were happy," she repeated, smaller, quieter. She didn't look up again, but Adora could see the tears starting to fall. "I don't *want* to remember. I want to stay here."

Maybe if Adora could convince herself that that was the only cost, that Catra could have everything she ever wanted, that they could both be free of Shadow Weaver's influence—if the only price Catra had to pay was thinking she could love Adora… maybe Adora could have lived with that. She couldn't make Catra happy, but if she could facilitate it, wasn't it worth the comfort of a lie? Catra *wanted* to stay here. She was willing to pay that price, to delude

herself into thinking Adora was worth any of the affection she'd shared. Catra was almost eager to sacrifice that piece of herself for the promise of a peaceful, fulfilling life.

Adora wanted to give it to her so, so badly. She desperately wanted to stay in this perfect, painted-over world, where she could be someone that didn't ruin everything she touched, where she hadn't betrayed Catra, or Etheria, where she could do what was right and still, somehow, be happy.

But this was all far too familiar.

Just because Catra was *willing* to love her didn't mean it was what she *wanted.* How many times had Shadow Weaver convinced them to do something they'd sworn they never would? How often had she elicited a surrender through her control over them, withholding food or sleep or affection? Adora had seen Catra—proud, willful Catra—weep with gratitude for the privilege of being *fed,* and she'd been starved for *this* her whole life. Of course she would be willing to be with Adora for a chance at it. She might even convince herself it was what she wanted.

Adora couldn't do that to her. She couldn't be another force exerting control over Catra, especially not for something as selfish as her own feelings.

"We can't," she said, small and broken, taking Catra's hands in hers. "Everything will be destroyed. And—it isn't real, and you deserve—you deserve the real future. The one that's waiting for you."

"What fucking future?" asked Catra, with a jagged laugh. "That's not a memory, it's a fucking *dream.* It's not going to happen. It's never going to happen."

"Catra—"

"Stop trying to spare my feelings and just say it," she snapped. "Stop hiding behind these bullshit excuses and tell me the real

reason. You haven't been able to *look* at me since you remembered. What the fuck happened? What the fuck did I *do?"*

"You didn't—" said Adora, squeezing her hands tighter, taking a fortifying breath. She had to know. She *deserved* to know. "You didn't do anything, Catra, please, this is all my fault. I'm so sorry, I didn't know—I'm *sorry.* I was never going to tell you, I—I was going to be there for you, for all of you. I *will* be."

"For who?" asked Catra. "For what? You've made it perfectly clear that you don't fucking want me, so that little vision was—"

"Of course I want you!" Adora burst out, unable to contain herself. "Fuck, Catra, that's the whole problem! I'm—I made you—if I didn't want you like this, if the portal wasn't trying to like, rewrite why you're in Bright Moon—if I didn't feel—if I wasn't—like this —"

"What?" Catra interrupted. Her face and posture had shifted abruptly while Adora was stammering out her explanation. She looked blank, shut down, all of her thoughts and feelings walled off again, like they had been on the battlefield.

Adora laughed humorlessly. "Thought for sure you would have figured it out by now," she mumbled, looking away as she fought the sting rising in her eyes. She'd finally done it, then. She'd broken them beyond repair, and now Catra would never be open with her again.

Maybe it was better this way. She certainly didn't deserve Catra in her life after she'd put her in this position.

"Feel like *what?"* Catra repeated, more forcefully, taking a step towards Adora.

"I'm in love with you," said Adora, voice thick around the lump in her throat. "Not just in the portal. Everywhere. Always. But I wasn't—I *swear* I wasn't going to do *anything* to mess with your future Catra, please, I promise. I want you to be that happy, I'll do fucking anything to make—"

“Shut up,” said Catra.

Adora shut up.

Catra was staring at her with wide, disbelieving eyes. “You… You love me? Like, for real?”

“Of course I do,” Adora said miserably, wiping a rogue tear from her cheek with the back of her hand. She had to make sure Catra knew this was her fault, that Catra hadn’t done anything wrong. “I’m not telling you to pressure you, or—or make you feel worse or *anything,* I just—you deserve to know why the portal did this, why it would—”

She stopped talking abruptly as Catra yanked her hands free and grabbed Adora by the front of her baldric, drawing her close enough that she could feel Catra’s breath on her face, see her own desperation reflected in her eyes. Adora swallowed, her mouth running dry, as Catra looked at her like she’d never seen her before. Like she couldn’t believe Adora had done this to her.

Frankly, Adora couldn’t either, but why was she so close?

“The very first thing I remembered,” Catra murmured, “even when I was pretending everything else was a fucked up nightmare, is that I’ve always loved you. In every world.”

The instant Adora had processed the words, as if she could see the thoughts connecting in Adora’s eyes, Catra’s lips were on hers. Soft but insistent, clumsier than the fading memories Adora clung to from their shared illusion of disjointed time, but so much realer for it. So much more *Catra.*

Adora kissed her back eagerly, desperately, until they had to break apart to breathe, foreheads pressed together and eyes still closed.

“Wow,” said Adora, barely above a whisper. “Okay.”

“Okay?” Catra repeated, voice colored with amusement.

"I *really* wasn't expecting that."

"You're such an idiot. Half of the Princess Alliance has figured it out by now and they've barely known me a *day."*

Adora gasped, drawing back slightly to look her in the eye. "Is that why you were threatening Bow?"

Catra laughed, free and open, and Adora's heart swelled at the sight and sound of it.

"You remember the Princess Alliance?" asked Adora, leaning back farther to watch her reaction. Catra nodded, still laughing.

"I remember everything. You especially. I'm pretty sure they could give me full amnesia and I'd still remember you."

"And… you love me?" Adora asked, still half-convinced she'd misheard somehow.

"You're such a fucking idiot," Catra repeated, with a fond little sigh. She looked absolutely besotted, and Adora's brain felt like it was melting out of her ears. "I've been in love with you since we were like six years old, Adora."

"You've *what?"* asked Adora, gaping at her.

"Yeah, so forgive me for thinking you weren't fucking interested, but—"

"Why didn't you *say* anything?"

"Uh, because Shadow Weaver would have skinned me alive?" drawled Catra. Adora winced. Right. They hadn't actually grown up running loose in the Whispering Woods; they'd been shackled by expectations and responsibilities, and occasionally literal shackles, trapped in the Fright Zone under the supervision of someone who had freely suggested *drowning infants* as a solution to Adora's lack of focus. "Besides, I didn't… I never thought you

could feel the same way. You're always so focused on the *mission."*

There was another crackling noise, and the smile dropped off Catra's face as she turned to look at the forest, where the glow of the encroaching portal was just visible through the trees.

"Come on," she said, grabbing Adora by the hand and towing her through the underbrush with no hesitation.

Dread began creeping back in, pressing against Adora's elation. She'd forgotten, for a moment, the circumstances that had led them here.

The mission.

Entrapta's solution.

She looked down at her hand in Catra's, chest squeezing painfully. How much harder would it be to give this up, now? It was one thing to walk to her death knowing she'd deserved it, that she'd taken advantage of her best friend, but this…

In the wake of her absolution, admitting to herself that there was a possibility Catra could actually *want* her—knowing that this was all her fault, for taking the sword to the Fright Zone, for letting it out of her sight for even an instant—

It wasn't just justice anymore. It was taking something from Catra, dangling promises that she'd stay for once and then dashing them on the rocks.

Was she a liar? Did it count as a lie of omission if she'd forgotten for those few, blissful moments that there was only ever one way her story would end?

"We need to figure out what Razz meant," said Catra. "Where's the beginning? Where you found the sword?"

Adora startled slightly, blinking at her. "You… don't want to stay anymore?"

"I mean, if it weren't falling apart, sure," said Catra. "I gotta say, not being a child soldier was kind of amazing. But if we don't get you out of here I'm pretty sure the world is going to explode, so —"

Adora stopped, their joined hands jerking Catra to an abrupt halt.

"What do you mean, get *me* out of here?" she demanded.

Catra didn't turn around for a moment, her ears flat against her head. She glanced back over her shoulder, blue eye half-hidden by her hair, looking at Adora through the protective curtain as if it made her invisible.

"Adora," she said, gently, pityingly. "I'm not going to make it."

Catra, eyes wild and fear tangible as her abdomen poured blood onto Adora's hands.

"Don't say that," Adora snapped. "Of course you are. We've seen it—you're going to get married, and have Cyra and Adam, and be happy. Be *alive."*

Catra turned all the way around at that, fixing Adora with an incredulous stare. Her mouth was half-open, as if to respond, but she closed it and shook her head as though clearing a thought from her mind.

"Adora," she said again, "if you take the sword, if you stay here… nobody can heal this."

Her form flickered between the outfit she'd worn in the portal and her usual clothes. They were free of blood, but the hole in her stomach had become a seeping black hole, cracking her torso like plaster around it. Purple and white flakes of her were chipping off, and Adora's stomach lurched with nausea.

"It's better this way," said Catra, injecting a false lightness into her tone as if it could soothe Adora's horror, the despair suddenly weighing her down. "If… if I stay, you can get out of here. You can fix everything. Maybe you'd even be able to get me out one day, with that fancy princess magic."

"I'm not leaving you," said Adora, struggling to contain the riot of emotions in her gut. "I'm never leaving you. Not again."

"Good, so we're agreed: You're not going to sacrifice yourself to fix this shit."

"I'm not leaving you in here! I *love* you, you asshole!"

And it made sense, didn't it? Maybe Catra loved Adora now, maybe she always had. At least this way it wasn't like they had to break up for Catra to meet her wife. She would mourn, but she'd move on eventually. She'd be happy.

One day.

Without Adora.

She closed her eyes, swallowing the welling grief.

If Catra lived, she'd be happy eventually. So she had to live.

"I love you too," said Catra, quiet but sincere. "So let me take the hit for once, okay? I'm not going to just cower behind you anymore. And it makes more sense if it's me. You have a better shot of getting me out after, right, princess?"

"I can't leave you," said Adora, voice breaking. "I can't."

"You have to. Soon," said Catra. She shook her head, visibly signaling the end of the discussion. As if Adora would give up that easily. "Where's the beginning?"

"I… I don't know." She looked around them, at the vast expanse of the Whispering Woods. "It should be here. This is where I

found the sword, it's where everything started—"

Catra squeezed her hand. "Everything?"

Adora smiled weakly. "It's where everything started to change," she amended.

"Let's try before that, then. Where you knocked yourself out by driving us into a tree."

"Okay, don't think that just because I love you that you can get away with pretending you didn't crash the skiff," said Adora, raising an eyebrow as Catra tugged her back into the woods.

"But what if I make this face while I try?" asked Catra, pouting up at her and letting her pupils go slack so they filled up most of her eyes. Adora screwed up her mouth, trying to hold in a coo. That was an extremely compelling argument.

"Nope," she said grimly, "I'm immune to your wiles. That hasn't worked since we were junior cadets."

"Are you sure? I seem to recall—" Catra started, breaking off with a gasp and stumbling. She gritted her teeth, clutching at her stomach. "No. No, it's too soon—"

"Catra!" said Adora, reaching for her, heart thudding audibly in her chest. This couldn't be happening already. Not like this.

"I'm not going out like this," growled Catra. "I'm not going to fucking fade away like—like fucking *mist.* Fuck. I'm supposed to go out in *style."*

She staggered forward, pieces of her ribcage flaking off into the air around her, dissolving like ashes in the wind. Adora rushed after her, trying to catch her by the elbow.

Her hand passed through like there was nothing there.

She stared down at her trembling fingers, at Catra's intangible arm, and tried to remain standing.

"I'm gonna burn out in a blaze of fucking glory, damn it," Catra hissed, pressing harder against her wound like she could force herself to stay together. "Fuck. Fuck!"

"No—Catra, please—" said Adora, reaching towards her. Catra looked at her, and reached back with one hand, stopping just before they'd phase through each other. The forest was getting brighter all around them, as the trees fell to the encroaching void. Rumbling, shattering, disintegrating.

"Adora," said Catra, anguished. Tears shone bright in her eyes, scintillating like the displaced stars spread out above them. Winking out one by one. "I'm—I'm sorry. For everything. I'm—it isn't supposed to *be* like this—"

"Catra," Adora said again, choked and ragged. She felt like she was being cut in half. One way or another, she would never see Catra again; lost either to death or the space between worlds. That constant presence by her side, or across from her on the battlefield, the looming, unspoken thing between them finally verbalized, just in time for the end of the world.

Just like they'd always promised.

"Don't do it," Catra begged, "Please don't do it Adora, it isn't worth it—"

"It's the *whole world,"* said Adora, her own tears spilling over. "I don't—I don't know what else to *do,* there's no one else *left—"*

"Fuck the world," said Catra. Her voice was starting to echo unnaturally, the portal's corruption crawling up her throat from her wound, even as the woods fell apart around them. "You're the only good thing in it. You can't—"

She gasped as the corruption reached her left eye, staining the gold a deep, oily black. Her fur bristled, her claws came

unsheathed, and her gaze went unfocused.

“It’s the portal,” she said, then shook her head before Adora could voice the ‘no shit’ on the tip of her tongue. “The portal that brought you here. That’s the beginning. I can—I can see it.”

“You’re helping me now?” Adora asked, eyeing her washed-out pupil warily. Was this still Catra, or was the portal influencing her again? A moment ago she was ready for the whole world to burn before Adora closed it.

Catra’s gaze refocused abruptly, zeroing in on Adora. “I can see it,” she whispered. Then she doubled over, trying and failing to muffle a groan of agony as she curled around her stomach, collapsing to her knees. Adora knelt with her, grasping uselessly at shoulders that slid through her fingers like smoke.

“*Fuck,* that hurts,” Catra panted, a single tear managing to escape as she gasped and rocked on her knees like she could escape from the pain. “Adora—please—”

“What do you need?” Adora asked desperately. She couldn’t help, she couldn’t touch—

Shadow Weaver holds her back as—

“What can I do?” she begged, shaking her head to clear it of shadows. “Please, Catra, how can I help you?”

“L—” Catra tried, squeezing her eyes shut and gritting her teeth before she could even get through a single word. “Love—you.”

“I love you t—”

Catra broke apart, black and white and purple shards dissolving into nothing as Adora could only watch, helpless.

Chapter End Notes

okay now i know you may be wanting to bite me and shake me and kill me. but i'm just gonna say again, one more time, that everything's gonna be fiiiiiiiine. don't even worry about it! it's allllllll good

it also occurred to me that even if you've checked out my tumblr you may not have seen my series tag, which has, you know. fun little drawings and me complaining about the writing process, and a meme my friend logan made roasting me for my attention span. mostly the complaining thing. [clears throat] anyway i'm sorry? 😬

Apocalypse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Interminable moments passed as Adora knelt on the crumbling ground, falling apart. Each minute felt like an eternity, but the urgency of them slipping away made her painfully conscious of her dwindling time. She was suspended in an instant of grief and agony, each beat of her heart bleeding precious seconds she'd never be able to reclaim.

Catra was gone. After *everything,* after a lifetime of defining themselves for and against each other, the thing that wrested them apart was Adora's own inability to hold on. To the sword, to Catra herself, to her own identity—everything she clung to inevitably slipped through her fingers, or was crushed by her desperate attempts to keep it close and safe.

She'd never see Catra's smile again, never hear her laugh. Never feel the weight of her, snug and solid in Adora's arms as a purr rumbled softly between them. Never wake to the warm cocoon of blankets in their— *her* bed, to the smell of moonlight and sleep and the mingling of Catra's scent with hers.

She would never again feel the rush of exhilaration when Catra challenged her, the thrill of their pointless competitions, the joy of getting lost in some joke only they understood. The love that filled her chest to the point it felt like it was bursting, that she had only just recognized, only just accepted—only just tasted, fingers skimming that perfect, illusory dream before it dissipated into bleak, unembellished reality.

Catra was *gone.*

And Adora… Adora was alone.

Maybe this was where she was always going to end up. There were so few people who could understand her, and so much she still didn't understand about herself. Isolation was inevitable, especially when taking her responsibilities as She-Ra into account. There were things even Catra wouldn't be able to forgive, to accept, to *love*— Adora had no illusions about who broke up with whom, in the original timeline.

So maybe it was better this way. Maybe it was better that she was alone for this, and now, before any of the people she loved could realize that she was so unworthy of their affection. She had no last regrets, no feelings unspoken—only a deep, deep sadness. A futile longing for more of those rare, shining moments of happiness.

The forest had splintered and decayed away around her, leaving her on a chunk of rock no bigger than the throne room, floating in an endless expanse of white.

A vivid purple tempest swirled overhead, and she could just make out the sword at its epicenter. Lines of white lanced through the wine-dark sky, like the petals of harebells flashing in the wind.

There was nothing left for her to do. No one else left to do it.

She had to act now, before it was too late.

She gained control of her breathing, forcefully, wiping away as many tears as she could, and was just climbing to her feet when a streak of orange hurtled from the sky, crashing to the ground a stone's throw from her.

Adora startled badly, reeling away and falling back to the ground, staring at this fresh mystery in shock, with no small degree of fear.

What else could this portal possibly do to her?

What had time and space thrown at her now?

The lump groaned and stirred, apparently alive, its voice deep and unfamiliar. “Always land on their feet, my ass,” it grumbled, gingerly unfurling.

It was a magicat, almost the same shade of orange as Catra, but with a coat brightened by rich copper stripes, rubbing their head through an explosion of dirty-blond hair.

As they rose to their feet and looked around, Adora’s eyes grew wider. They were absolutely massive, at least a head taller than her and twice as broad, their eyes a bright, stormy blue against—

Wait.

“Adam?” she choked, scrambling to her feet. He perked up at the sight of her, then looked around again, frowning.

“Oh. Portal shenanigans, huh?” he asked, crossing the short distance to look her over. “Whoof, look at you! You’re so young!”

“You’re so—old?” Adora managed, still reeling. He was at least her age, maybe even older. “What—how are you—you shouldn’t be here!”

Adam grinned, sharp and mischievous just like Catra, and it squeezed Adora’s heart painfully. “Oh, come on,” he drawled, puffing out his chest. “Time and space can’t stop us from getting into trouble any more than they stopped *you.* When are we? Did Mom pull the—wait, how do you know who I am?”

“It’s an alternate timeline, dumbass,” said a scathing, eerily familiar voice. Adora jumped, whirling around, and this time it was easy to recognize the stranger in front of her.

She looked just like Catra. Even if her eyes matched, and her fur and hair were lighter, even if she was absolutely *covered* in freckles instead of gently dusted, Cyra was her spitting image. It was like someone had taken a picture of Catra and colored over it.

And managed to braid its hair, somehow. There was no way Catra's hair would cooperate enough to be braided.

"Cyra?" Adora asked, voice breaking a little with a fresh wave of grief.

They were grown up. They were happy and safe and they *made it,* but—

She was going to miss this. She was never going to meet them. Not for real.

A terrible gratitude warred with the heartbreak in her chest. She got to see them. She got to know they were okay, that she wasn't dying for nothing—

"Whoa," said Cyra, softening with concern as she too moved closer to Adora, laying a hand on her arm. She was Catra's height, though given her hair was actually tamed she was likely an inch or two taller. "You okay?"

"I'm—I—" Adora tried, struggling to stave off another round of tears. "You're so *big."*

"I work out," said Cyra, flexing a bare arm and grinning. In contrast to Adam's, it wasn't one of Catra's expressions—it was too smug and too lopsided, but still strangely familiar. Cyra had Catra's same lithe, wiry build, a rapier beside Adam's broadsword.

She was wearing Bright Moon style clothes. They both were.

"Hey, don't worry," Adam assured Adora, low and soothing in a way that reminded her of Bow's gentle, nurturing presence. He rested an arm across her shoulders, leaning over to butt his head against her temple affectionately. "It'll be okay, promise. Me and Cyra are here now."

Adora broke again, curling into his chest, the overwhelming familiarity of what should be a perfect stranger. He folded around

her, warm and comforting and protective, the deep rumble of his purr ripping a sob from between her teeth.

They were so much like Catra, but there was so much about them that she recognized from her friends. Her *family* . Bow's comforting warmth, Glimmer's rash leaps into the unknown. Little baubles and shared expressions that could only be born of spending an obscene amount of time with the Best Friend Squad, mannerisms she didn't realize she could recognize until she saw them adopted by Catra's children.

It was everything and everyone that Adora loved distilled into liquid starlight, anointing the children she'd adored since the moment she laid eyes on them.

"I'm sorry," she choked out into Adam's chest, clutching at his shirt. "I'm sorry, I love you, I'm sorry."

"Don't be," murmured Cyra from behind her, rubbing up and down her back. "It's okay. We love you too, we're here. We're not going anywhere."

"You won't," Adora agreed fiercely, "I promise, I'm going to—I'm going to protect you. No matter what."

"Adam, stop blubbering," said Cyra. Adora drew back in alarm, looking up at Adam, whose face was streaming with tears despite the purr still rolling through his chest.

"I can't help it!" he whined, voice strained with emotion. "I'm a sympathy crier!"

"Pull it together. We need to find out what we're working with," said Cyra. She kept one hand between Adora's shoulders, raising the other up to her brother as if requesting a high five. Adam sniffed pitifully, raising his own hand, and pressed it against hers.

Adora's breath caught as a web of bright blue light materialized around them, extending to the edges of the chunk of rock they were standing on. It was beautiful, cool and sparkling, a faint

glow of every color imaginable diffusing around it in a soft, smoky rainbow.

"You—you can do *magic?"* she asked, staring in shock as the web faded from view.

"You do remember that we accidentally invented time travel as infants, right?" asked Cyra, snorting. "Of course we can. You taught us the basics when we were *toddlers."*

"Taught you? I'm not magic," said Adora, frowning. "The sword is magic."

Adam and Cyra stared at her for a moment, blinking in apparent confusion, before looking at each other, words passing between them too quick for Adora to follow.

"It's an alternate timeline," said Adam, a hopeful, pleading note in his voice that Adora didn't fully understand.

"That doesn't mean we can do whatever we want," said Cyra, but she had the same reluctant tone Catra got when she just needed to be wheedled into doing something she secretly already wanted to do. "There are some things people need to realize for themselves, you know? And anyway, we need to focus."

"Ugh," said Adam, stepping around Adora to stand at his sister's side. "Fifty-fifty or you wanna do your sorcery thing?"

"I'll handle it. Just keep the power levels even," said Cyra, moving her hands in a wide circle to form an elaborate sigil. It looked different than the ones Adora had seen Castapella weave, more complex, a series of smaller circles joined around a central pattern and layered in front of each other like panes of glass.

"This would be way easier with the sword," said Adam, almost petulant despite the tears still wet on his cheeks.

"If you didn't want to be a battery, you should've asked to borrow it before we left," said Cyra. Adam laid a hand on her back, fingers

suffused with the same bright, opalescent shimmer of colors as their spellwork. Cyra's sigil grew brighter immediately, like he was pouring magic into her to fuel the spell.

"You can't do this, by the way," Adam told Adora, looking sideways at her. "I mean, maybe you could learn sorcery, I don't know. I think you're on team 'what's the point' with me."

"*This* is the point," said Cyra, tail lashing impatiently. The same frustration Glimmer showed when someone brought up an old argument. Beams of light bloomed from the sigils in front of Cyra, stretching up and growing around them. "If your inelegant parlor tricks were actually *good* for anything—"

"Excuse me! I happen to be amazing at breaking walls, and dimensions, and all kinds of records for stuff, so—"

"Oh, can you stop the encroaching collapse of the spacetime continuum without me? By all means Adam, be my fucking guest." She flicked her wrist as the spell dissolved into mist, a faint dome projected over their heads, sheltering them from the chaos without.

"You can't swear in front of Mom!" Adam protested, scandalized. "She's going to be so disappointed in us, can't you pretend we're polite for five minutes?"

"Mom?" said Adora, interrupting the beginning of Cyra's comeback. She looked around, half-hoping and half-terrified to find future-Catra waiting for her.

"Uh, yeah?" said Adam. "I promise we're usually super good, it's just that ever since you said we were allowed to swear on special occasions Cyra's gone kind of—"

"Wait, *me?"*

The twins looked at each other, then back at her, both visibly confused.

"You call me Mom?" Adora clarified, as baffled as they looked.

"You're kidding, right?" asked Cyra, staring at Adora in disbelief so profound she might as well have asked them who Catra *was.* "Please tell me you're kidding."

"Huh?" asked Adam, still frowning. "I'm lost."

"M—Adora. Who do you think our parents are?" Cyra asked, slowly, like Adora wouldn't understand the question. Adam's frown grew, and he looked between them like they were speaking another language.

"Catra and—her wife?" said Adora, voice tipping embarrassingly high. It felt awkward to admit she still didn't know the woman's name, given all that she apparently owed to her, but—

"Uh, *you're* her wife," said Adam. Cyra smacked his arm. "Ow! What did I say?"

"I'm… what?" said Adora.

"You're her wife," said Cyra, huffing at Adam. "You're our other mom. We thought you knew, why the fuck were you so excited to see us?"

"I'm… You're… Wait—"

Adora stared, still as a statue as her eyes darted over them, taking in their features anew.

It was like receiving the cipher at the end of a code-breaking test, understanding filling the gaps she'd wondered at in quiet awe. The broadness of their shoulders, the color of their eyes—Adam's blond hair, Cyra's lopsided smile. They were all *hers.* But that didn't mean—they had pieces of Bow, of Glimmer—nothing physical, true, but—There was no way, right?

"No you're not," she whispered, like it could stop her voice from breaking. "You—you can't be. You…"

"I can assure you that we are," said Cyra. The tone was Catra's, fond and condescending, but the expression was *Adora's,* all soft and patient but with that edge of smugness she got when she was too comfortable with someone. "I'm pretty sure Mom would rather die than admit it, but that's why Adam's such a muscle-bound freak. That did *not* come from the cat side of the family."

The way she said Mom for Catra was different than the way she said it for… for Adora. She couldn't pinpoint whether it was inflection, or intonation, but she knew instinctively that it was Catra being referred to.

Her heart trembled inside her chest.

"But you're perfect," said Adora. Her voice broke again as she swallowed around a lump in her throat.

Cyra's smirk faltered, melting into concern. Adam leaned over her, tilting his head to one side like Catra did when she was trying to figure something out, and the undisguised compassion on his face —the lack of an instinct to hide it away—felt like it was hammering into Adora's ribcage.

They were perfect, and happy, and there was no way this was real.

Even if she managed not to ruin any child with her for a mother through genetics alone, there was no way she could raise *them.* Not Cyra and Adam, not these—these brave and soft and incredible people standing in front of her.

She squeezed her eyes shut, but when she opened them, they were still there, watching her.

Stop.

Stop.

"Stop," she managed to choke out, digging the heels of her hands into her eyes.

“Mom,” said Adam, his enormous hands bracketing her shoulders, gentle and tentative.

She didn’t drop her hands. She couldn’t look at him again, couldn’t let herself believe this, it would hurt so much worse when she woke up—

Except she was never *going* to wake up, because she was going to be trapped in here forever—

A fresh wave of dread threatened to drown her as she realized the implications anew. She was going to be trapped in here. *Forever.*

“I’m sorry,” she said again, breath shuddering on every exhale. She tipped forward into his arms again, letting him hold her. Maybe it was okay to pretend, just for a minute. It was probably one of the last things she’d ever do, and she could hardly turn her nose up at comfort now.

“You’re okay,” Adam rumbled, his purr rolling through her hands where they were still pressed to her face, heavy and reassuring like her and Catra’s old blanket in the bunks. “It’s okay, I promise. We’re gonna fix it.”

“I have to save them,” she murmured, fingers clutching the fabric of his shirt. “I’m—I have to, but—but I’m—if—”

If she was their other mother, and she died here, Adam and Cyra would never exist.

And it would be her fault.

But if she didn’t stop the portal, *nothing* would exist, and it would *still* be her fault.

“Mom,” said Cyra, butting her forehead against Adora’s shoulder. Her voice was so gentle, and patient, like Adora was something fragile and precious and wasn’t about to erase all three of them from existence. Adora swallowed thickly, burying her face against Adam’s chest.

"Mom," said Cyra again, more insistently. She pressed harder against Adora's shoulder, until it was more of an aggressive nuzzle than a headbutt.

Adora reached out for her, drawing her into the circle of Adam's arms, wedging her own face between the two. She still couldn't look at them.

She couldn't do this.

She couldn't *not.*

She wasn't even crying. She tried to speak, to answer Cyra, but her throat wasn't working the way it was supposed to. She was shaking almost violently, the same frequency as Adam's purr, but she wasn't crying. She'd cried when she'd lost Catra. It felt like she'd cried forever.

What was wrong with her? Why wasn't she crying? She was going to kill them and she couldn't even spare a single tear? Didn't she love them? Didn't she care about her *fucking children?*

"Mom," said Cyra, gently knocking their heads together. "Look at me, okay? You're not going to die. Nobody's going to die."

Adora curled her fingers tighter in the fabric of Cyra's shirt, refusing to move.

Cyra didn't know. She was so used to the portals that she and Adam could make that she didn't understand the consequences, and—

Someone tugged on her ponytail, dislodging her from where she'd been squished between them. Immediately, she felt exposed, vulnerable, but they were both still surrounding her, both purring and patient and *how was she supposed to do this?*

"Nobody's going to die," Cyra repeated firmly, meeting her eyes.

Fuck, she had Adora's eyes, how had she not *noticed*—

"Time out for a sec, okay?" Cyra went on, ducking out of Adam's arms. "Forget what you think you know about portals. I doubt Entrapta was able to dumb anything down well enough for you to process a word of it beyond 'end of the world'."

Adam dropped his chin on top of Adora's head, hunching over to make up the height difference. He wriggled slightly so they were both facing Cyra, folding his arms over Adora's shoulders so his purr was right behind her ears.

"How much do you know about portals?" he asked, jaw bumping into her ponytail when he spoke.

Adora shook her head, half-shrugging. Her eyes drifted back to Cyra's face, flitting from detail to detail. She wrinkled her nose when she was thinking. Was that something Catra did that Adora just hadn't noticed? Something *she* did? Had it been adopted from one of the people Cyra had known growing up, or was it just her? Something unique and adorable and *precious,* something Adora should be fighting to preserve?

"I—gateways," she managed. "Entrapta said portals are gateways that… connect areas of space."

"And time," said Cyra. That tone reminded her of Angella, actually, when she was prompting Glimmer to notice something obvious but trying to be gentle about it. Adora swallowed hard.

"And time," she agreed, voice hoarse. "She said the sword is powering it from the inside, and we have to take it out to turn it off. But that…"

"Somebody would have to stay behind," Adam finished for her, humming discontentedly.

"So she wasn't *wrong* exactly, but—don't freak out!" said Cyra, raising her hands as if to forestall another breakdown when Adora flinched. "It's… the idea of 'inside' is kind of more involved than you're imagining. You're thinking in three dimensions; you need to start thinking in *four."*

Adora stared back at her blankly. Cyra groaned.

"It's complicated, alright? It's not that someone has to stay behind as like a sacrificial counterweight, it's that taking the sword out fixes the hole in reality too fast for them to end up on the right side of the 'door'. Okay?"

Adora grimaced. That did *not* sound okay. It wasn't as though they could undo it any other way; they'd still have to remove the sword, so she'd still have to stay here.

"Mom," said Adam, "we can literally travel through time. And space. Nothing is too fast for us, and even if it were, we could just get back inside no problem."

And that was true, but if they were the only ones who could… He couldn't be suggesting she let one of them take her place?

"No," said Adora, stiffening in his hold, "absolutely not! You can't __"

"Relax," drawled Cyra, rolling her eyes. "He's saying we can just pop you out on the right side of reality, not that it has to be one of us grabbing the sword. We know better than to try and get between the mighty She-Ra and literally any threat."

"What do you mean?" Adora asked warily.

"You're the poster child for the Sword of Protection, Mom," said Adam. "And, you know, we've heard the stories. You have kind of a martyr complex."

"I—what? No I don't," she protested immediately.

"*Somebody* told us once that during the war, you wanted to die *for* something," said Cyra.

Adora flinched, nearly jarring herself from Adam's arms. Who told them that? Who *knew* that? Was she wearing her weaknesses so openly in their time?

"I… it isn't a *martyr* complex, though. To want it to… mean something," she managed, halfway mumbling. "For it to help people."

"You don't have to die to help people," Adam told her sternly. "Try to focus on the fact that you dying would *hurt* them. And not just emotionally! Who would run around taking cannon blasts and throwing up miraculous, last-minute shields if you were dead, huh?"

"I know!" said Adora, struggling not to snap. "I—I *know* that. I don't *want* to die."

"But you feel like it's inevitable, right?" Cyra pressed. "Even meeting us, even knowing you make it out of the war, it doesn't feel like it's true yet."

Adora pursed her lips, avoiding eye contact with her… daughter. Fuck, why did that hurt so much to think? "There are no guarantees," she said, voice low and a little rough. "We've already changed the timeline. What if it's too much? Catra—" her voice broke, and she closed her eyes, taking a deep breath. Adam hugged her a little closer, and she lifted a hand to his arm, holding onto it tight.

"Catra's hurt. I don't—I don't know what happened in your timeline, but Hordak stabbed her and I don't think he would've if they were still on the same side, and—"

She ducked into the shelter of Adam's forearms, burying her too-hot eyes in his fur, trying to keep her breathing even. Neither of the twins said anything, waiting for her to finish.

"And what if it's too late?" she asked, voice breaking again. "What if—even if I don't die in here, even if I could heal the wound, what if it's been too long? What if she—what if she doesn't make it? I don't know *anything* about our future, all I have is—is proof of what would have been possible if I hadn't *ruined* it."

She didn't move, struggling to regain control of her breathing as the twins continued to wait in silence. Probably communicating through expression alone, talking about how disappointing it was to see their mother, the 'mighty She-Ra', looking like this. Acting like this, like a little kid who wasn't ready to accept the realities of war.

"What if?" Cyra asked, after a long moment. Adam slid away from Adora's back, moving to stand beside his sister, removing Adora's hiding place in the process. She raised her red, stinging eyes to look at them, ready to accept their judgment. Disgust, anger, or worst of all, pity—she could bear it. She had to. Let them see her as she was, and understand how little faith they should have that she could pull this off.

"What if?" Adam echoed. He slung an arm over Cyra's shoulders, and both of them were smiling at her so softly, with so much affection she could practically feel it. Adora faltered at the unexpectedness of it all, breath hitching in her chest.

"What would you do?" asked Cyra, reaching out and taking Adora's hand, clasping it tight, ducking a little to meet her instinctively-lowered eyes. "If you got back out of here and Mom was still hurt, would you just give up?"

"Of course not," said Adora, frowning. "I'd—I know how to heal now. But—"

"But if she died you wouldn't even try? You'd just leave her there?" Adam interrupted. They were still smiling at her, eyes shining with love and understanding, and it was so *confusing.* Why were they asking questions that they *must* know the answer to?

"No," she insisted, looking between them. "I would never just…"

"Give up," they agreed in unison, nodding.

"We promise, Mom," said Cyra, squeezing her hand. "Everything is going to be okay. You have no idea what you're capable of."

"Don't think about it like it's something you *have* to do," said Adam. He took her other hand, linking the three of them together. "This isn't an expectation you have to meet, or a destiny you have to fulfill. You're already met it, fulfilled it, whatever—it's as much a part of you as any part of your personality. You're cocky, you're a terrible liar, you go *way* overboard when you prepare for stuff, and you never give up on anything, ever."

"It doesn't matter how hurt Mom is or isn't when you get out," said Cyra. "You'll try to heal her if she needs it, and that's all you can do. If you have to try more than once, or try something else, then you will. As long as you're not stuck in here, she's going to be fine."

"How do you know?" Adora whispered, taking a shaky breath.

"I'm pretty sure *you'd* invent time travel if she wasn't," said Adam. "Trust us on this one, Mom. She'll be fine."

"And so will *you,* if you can resist sacrificing yourself for ten fucking minutes," Cyra added.

"I'm… I can do that."

"Which timeline even is this?" asked Adam. "You've met us before, right? When?"

"Like a couple days ago," said Adora, rubbing at her eyes with the back of her wrist. He stubbornly clung to her hand. "You were… you were just little tiny babies. I still can't believe how cute you were."

"Okay, use of the past tense there has been noted," said Cyra, sniffing faux-haughtily. "That would be… right after Shadow Weaver turned up, right?"

"Yeah," said Adora, frowning at the ground.

"Alright, perfect," said Adam, nodding. He reached up over his head, drawing a circle with one claw that solidified into a swirling

vortex as soon as the line connected.

"Wh—wait!" Adora squawked, as it began to descend, sweeping over all three of them. The world around her dissolved into a whirl of darkness, which was actually comforting after the stark white of the abyss.

"Easy, easy," said Adam, chuckling as the abyss resolved around them. The vortex raged directly overhead, and in the space between their clasped hands, just at waist-height…

The sword floated, unassuming, at the eye of the storm.

"I was just taking us to where you could reach," Adam explained with a smile.

"It did unfreeze time, so things are gonna start falling apart again, but we have a second," said Cyra, drawing a second circle, this time parallel to their bodies. "Here's what's going to happen: Pulling the sword has a kickback. It's going to throw you through this portal, right back to where you need to be. Sound good?"

"What's going to happen to you?" asked Adora, clutching tighter at her hand.

"We're going to go home and re-draw some sigils," said Adam, a little sheepishly. "We weren't actually *trying* to go back in time with this one, just get to the space between dimensions to grab some samples."

"That's the trouble with leaving the spacetime continuum," said Cyra, with a commiserating grimace that Adora couldn't really reciprocate. "It's always so darn unpredictable."

"But you won't, like… disappear, right?"

"'Course not," Cyra assured her. "We might have to time travel to get back once we've got everything we need, but like… that's sort of the easy part."

“I love you,” Adora blurted, tears finally welling up. “You know I love you, right? I can’t—I can’t believe you’re real. I’m so…”

“We know, Mom,” said Adam, rolling his eyes like it could detract from his pleased purr. “We love you too.”

“And we’re proud of you,” added Cyra. Adora’s breath rushed out of her, shuddering like she’d been punched in the chest. “Both of you. You’re the best moms ever.”

“Minus some overprotective tendencies, but you relaxed eventually,” said Adam, eyes sparkling.

“I’m—I’m proud of you, too. I can’t… I don’t—”

“Yeah, yeah,” said Cyra. “Save it for Mom. And go to therapy!”

“*Please* go to therapy.”

“Thank you,” said Adora, curling forward, towards the sword. She wanted to hug them, but with their hands in hers and a blade between them this was the best she could do. “If—thank you.”

“We love you guys,” said Adam, stooping slightly to peck her on the forehead. “Cyra, would you like to do the honors?”

Cyra sighed, more than a little fondly. “Take care of each other,” she told Adora, guiding her hand to the hilt of the sword.

Metal warmed beneath her fingers, and the world vanished in a blaze of white.

Chapter End Notes

> i have consulted a few pals on the chapter title & they have assured me while most people do not know the literal meaning of the word apocalypse that i should write the kind of stuff i would like & if there is one thing i love on this bitch of an earth it is wordplay.

when the solution first occurred to me, the kittens felt like a bit of a ~~deus ex machina~~ fēliculae ex magīa, but hear me out here: the entire premise of this series is magical time-traveling fankids accidentally course-correcting their dumbass moms. and more significantly it's literally the only way adora was going to figure out they were her kids without like, meeting them in real time & she Had to realize at some point or why did i even write sequels you know

plus my second best plan was to approach it scientifically & that would have necessitated a fucking glossary.

i would like to take the opportunity to thank y'all for your patience & feedback, though. i've been having a Hell of a weekend & going back and reading old comments helped combat some of the spiraling. appreciate each & every one of you ♥

After

Chapter Notes

> three years ago today, i was on bed rest after a (fairly minor) surgery. they had me working from home, which was kinda dumb because i ran a mailroom at the time & couldn't do 95% of my job, but i was getting paid to lay in bed all day, so like... whatever you say, boss. but i was no longer on painkillers and super bored, so i decided to start watching this she-ra show i'd heard about, and, well... i'm still spiraling into madness to this very day!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was blasted back, bright white blinding her as she collided with something solid and metallic, something that couldn’t have been in the space between worlds with her. Her ears rang as she tried to blink the spots out of her vision, struggling into a sitting position.

There was a muted, mechanical roaring sound, trailing off into a whine like a tank with a disconnected fuel line, and a clamor of voices all around her. Several were calling her name, sounding upset, but she couldn’t hear the one that mattered most.

She forced herself onto her knees, vision finally clearing enough to reveal an astounded Hordak staring at his own hands, apparently ignoring the crumpled figure at his feet.

Adora half-ran, half-crawled to Catra’s side, the sword still clutched in her fist from inside the portal. As she glanced down to raise it, she realized she was already transformed.

Good. She needed to be quick.

Catra didn’t stir as Adora pulled her up into her arms, aside from a flicker of her eyelids.

Her breathing was shallow, faint and rasping. Her fur tacky with blood and cool to the touch. Definitely in shock. And based on how sluggish the bleeding was becoming…

Adora cradled her with one arm, resting the back of her other hand over the wound, careful not to exacerbate it but instinctively trying to apply pressure, despite the sword in her clenched fist.

Hordak was saying something, people were still shouting, but it was all static in Adora's ears.

She concentrated only on the memory of future-Adora's healing lesson, the steady hand that had wrapped around her own to gentle her grip.

Don't force it, she'd said, smiling so gently it made her face look like a stranger's, *if you're angry at yourself you're only going to blow stuff up. Just breathe.*

Catra was *dying,* fading away, and all Adora was doing was sitting there holding the hilt of her stupid sword to the wound. Frustrated tears welled up in her eyes, and she squeezed them shut, trying to breathe evenly. Trying to focus, to remember.

It's okay to be afraid, future-Adora had said. *There's so much magic, it feels like it would be easy for something to go wrong. For it to spiral out of control. But you have to admit that: That you're afraid. You have to* feel *it.*

It was all she *could* feel, the terror stealing over her heart, seeping into her veins. Catra needed her. She was the only one who could help. Adam and Cyra believed in her, they'd been so sure she could do this, they hadn't even come back with her to make sure—

I— we *spent so much of our life pushing down every thought and feeling that didn't seem safe.* Future-Adora had been so soft, Cyra cradled in the nest of her folded legs and Adam trying to climb up her jacket to get at her ponytail. Adora had been torn with envy, half yearning for the easy affection between future-Adora and

Catra's children and half wondering if she had ever been held like that, on an alien world she could barely imagine. *Wanting answers, wanting freedom, wanting to be closer to people—none of it was* allowed *. And to suddenly gain all of that power? To be cut loose from everything, good and bad, and tossed into this whole new world with the strength to destroy* everything, *maybe even by accident? That scared the crap out of me. And I know it scares you, too. It's okay to feel that. It's okay to feel like you don't want it, and to feel like it's all you* ever *wanted. You aren't in the Horde anymore. It's safe to feel things. Even messy, conflicting things that don't make any sense.*

She let the emotions roll through her, waves of fear and longing and love, love, love. The hope that had bloomed in her heart when Catra said she was leaving the Horde. The peace she'd felt, kissing her in the fake-Bright Moon gardens. The devastation and disbelief and *joy* of meeting the kittens, both times.

Golden light seeped in behind her eyelids, warm and gentle. With her eyes closed she could almost sense it, flowing first around and then into Catra, suffusing her injuries with magic.

You're going to feel it no matter what, future-Adora had told her, with a knowing smile and her arms full of babies she'd never admitted were hers, *so you might as well accept it. It doesn't matter how you think you're supposed to be. It matters how you feel, and it matters what you* do.

She opened her eyes, pouring what felt like infinite emotion into Catra's wounds, trying to will her powers to understand, to help protect the other half of her heart. Flesh and skin and fur knit themselves together under Adora's careful, diligent attention, and Catra's breathing evened out. She shifted unconsciously in Adora's arms, like her body finally had enough energy to realize it was being held.

Adora blew out a shaky breath, holding her a little closer. They were both drenched in blood, and Catra's shirt was beyond salvation, but she was *here.* She was *alive.*

The rest of the world began to filter in, the insistent calls of her name now mingled with cries of Catra's. There was the clamor of a renewed battle, metal against ice, magic against the zaps of stun batons, scattered grunts of pain, but it was less fevered than it had been before the portal opened.

None of it mattered.

Adora was finally able to tear her eyes away from the ghost of Catra's wound to look at her face, stomach tying itself in knots. Catra's mismatched eyes slitted open, weary but filled with such powerful relief that Adora would have made her sit down if she weren't already in her lap.

"Catra," she whispered, breathless and reverent and still a little disbelieving.

"Hey Adora," said Catra, hoarse and quiet but so *relieved,* like she was surprised to see Adora. Had she expected Adora to give up on her? "I see you managed not to kill yourself."

Oh. Right. The last thing she remembered would be Adora arguing that she should be trapped in a void outside of space and time forever.

"I had a little help," said Adora, less urgent realities finally beginning to sink in as a warm, warm smile curled her lips. "See, it turns out future-me had some kids too."

Catra's eyes widened, and she had the audacity to look nervous, though she swiftly tried to conceal that. "O-oh?" she tried, glancing away like this was brand new information that didn't interest her at all.

"You little brat," huffed Adora, grinning at her. "You knew the whole time, didn't you? I thought maybe you'd convinced yourself it was someone else, but— "

"Adora, they look exactly like you and have *magic powers,"* said Catra, scowling up at her. "You just didn't want to see it. And it's

not like I was going to *make* you."

Adora's smile faded into something softer, pulling Catra a little further into her lap. The noise had all but died down around them. Catra was right; she *hadn't* wanted to see it. But future-Adora had been right too, telling her to let herself feel things she didn't think she was supposed to. That it would bring her peace. That it would make her strong.

Adora was finally starting to understand what she'd meant.

"Catra, I…"

"No," said a growling, furious voice above her. Adora reluctantly stopped focusing on Catra, looking up at a seething Hordak, whose face was turning around his sanctum like he couldn't believe what he was seeing.

What had he seen in the portal? Had the strange, wish-granting effects been universal, or keyed to Adora through her sword? Was Hordak happy there, or was he being tormented like Adora had felt he deserved, after how the portal was opened?

She wasn't sure what he deserved, now. She kind of hoped he'd been happy, and seen how different things could be. That maybe this was what he needed to turn things around.

(But also, she was still covered in Catra's blood, so if he were maybe a *little* tortured, that wouldn't be the end of the world. Morally speaking.)

"It's over, Hordak," Adora said coolly, struggling to remember what she'd been saying before they'd woken up in the portal. Something about redemption? She definitely gave him a chance to back down. And he had *definitely* rejected that.

"It's just beginning," he snapped, glowering at her but making no move to attack. "Once my brother receives my transmission, he shall bring the might of his entire empire down upon this world. Not one of you—"

"Your brother sent you away to die, dipshit," Catra interrupted, using Adora's shoulder to push her way to her feet. She swayed a little, shaky on her legs, but didn't let it deter her from glaring at him. Adora's arms felt empty without her, the chill of the room against her blood-soaked uniform unsettling in at least three different ways.

(Why could She-Ra's clothes even *get* wet?)

"Silence!" barked Hordak, lip curling in the beginnings of a snarl. He raised a hand as if to strike her, his eyes flitting around the room, taking in the bound and unconscious members of his retinue, some frozen, some gagged, all defeated.

Adora took it in too. The thrill of victory, the relief that her friends were unharmed—well, Kyle was hopelessly tangled up in some bolas, but honestly he'd probably done that himself somehow. The grim satisfaction at seeing her childhood instructors, who had made life so much harder than it needed to be, defeated and helpless and feeling the way they'd made her feel. The way they'd made so many children feel, in the name of the Horde.

She let that thought consume her for a moment, holding it tightly, the mingled rage and despair and guilt and a lingering feeling of loyalty, like she was still, somehow, betraying them. Like it hadn't been the other way around all along. The fury for thousands of destroyed lives, hundreds upon hundreds of children like Adam and Cyra who were raised to know only the cold and vicious rigidity of servitude. Dimly, she registered the faint glow of magic around her, growing more powerful the longer she dwelt on the warring feelings of injustice and the instinct to conform, to apologize for deviating so far from the path laid out before her.

She didn't *want* to follow that path. It made no sense to feel like a failure when she was *rejecting* it, when she was *choosing* to fight for what was true and just, instead of the insidious lies that tried to poison her against the world. Against herself.

She looked back to Hordak, allowing herself to feel the messy, conflicting emotions she had towards him in particular. Fury, disgust, resentment. A swelling of sympathy that hadn't quite been smothered, even if it was difficult to reach with her protectiveness *literally* overflowing.

She loomed over him, more conscious of her height than she'd ever been, magic pouring off of her and Catra safe behind her back. She couldn't remember moving between them. One moment she'd been getting to her feet, watching him glare at Catra, and the next she was in his face, emanating power the same way Swift Wind flared his wings to intimidate their enemies.

"It's *over,* Hordak," she said again, voice low. He glowered up at her, and she tried to pretend she wasn't smug over the flash of fear in his eyes for all of five seconds before letting that too stoke the magic around her. He had nothing to fear from her, so long as he didn't try anything stupid.

She reached out a hand to her left, eyes still locked with Hordak's. "Scorpia."

Scorpia stepped forward, wringing her pincers, looking back at Catra for approval.

"Knock him out," said Adora.

"Oh, uh—you got it, boss!" said Scorpia, with a nervous laugh.

Hordak opened his mouth to protest, but hit the ground before he could so much as draw a breath. Adora watched him for a moment, taking the time to ensure he was truly unconscious and not just faking. She tracked the rise and fall of his chest, then decided it was better not to risk it.

"Perfuma," she said, holding her hand out to the princesses next, braced in case Hordak suddenly leapt to his feet and attacked.

"I'm on it," said Perfuma, skittering under Adora's outstretched arm and conjuring enough roots and vines to bind him, a

determined smile splitting her face.

Adora's shoulders sagged as she fully relaxed for the first time since exiting the portal, She-Ra's form dropping with them. She swayed on her feet as the magic keeping her upright washed away.

"Easy, dipshit," said Catra, coming up beside her and snaking an arm around her waist.

"We… we did it," said Adora. She raised her head, looking Catra in the eye. "We beat Hordak."

"And the top brass," said Catra, with a smug little grin at their former commanding officers. "A few captains out on assignment, a couple supply lines to disrupt, and the only troops left will be cadets. We still need to set up a new system to handle them all, but…"

"We *won,"* Adora breathed, leaning in to press their foreheads together, to revel in victory with the only person who could truly understand what that meant to her.

Their lives had been consumed by the Horde from the moment they were brought in, their every action taken with the looming knowledge of its power and regulations. Even without the extra attention from Shadow Weaver, the Horde had shaped all of Etheria—razing, assimilating, exploiting. They were raised to be cogs in the great war machine, to facilitate all that pain and destruction. The training, the depersonalization, pitting everyone against each other to convince them that was just the way the world worked—they'd been engineered for a purpose, and now, at last, the machine they were made to serve had been ground forcibly to a halt.

Hordak was right, in a way. It *was* just beginning. There was so much that had to be done to dismantle his influence, both in his soldiers' minds and the surrounding countryside.

Catra knew that. Catra probably already had a plan to get started. Adora was going to have to learn to relax and leave the planning in more capable hands—there was no one who could pull this off quite like Catra. No one else who knew what was at stake.

"Hang on," said Glimmer. Adora startled, nearly leaping out of Catra's grip. She'd forgotten the rest of the princesses for a moment. "What the *fuck* was that?"

Perfuma made a small noise of distress, gesturing at a thoroughly unruffled Frosta, who was much more concerned with securing various Horde officers to the ground.

"What, should we not have won your little war for you?" drawled Catra, eyes sparkling with mischief.

"No no no no," said Glimmer, looking between Catra and Adora with wide, slightly manic eyes. "I mean—you were, like—"

"Who?" asked Mermista, raising an eyebrow.

"Adora! And *Catra!"*

"What about them?" asked Scorpia, with a puzzled frown.

"They were *together,"* Glimmer hissed, blushing. "Like—like making out in the garden together! Sharing lewd comments over breakfast together!"

"Oh!" said Perfuma, spinning to face them with wide, delighted eyes. *"Oh!"*

"Are we… am I allowed to…?" Scorpia asked hesitantly.

Catra sighed, exasperated fondness evident in her smile. "Yes, Scorpia, you can talk about it now."

"I totally figured it out first!" said Scorpia, all in a rush like the words had been straining to burst out of her since she'd first pieced things together.

“I think *Catra* figured it out first,” said Bow, eyes still shining.

“What? Scorpia wasn’t even *there!”* said Glimmer, looking between them and apparently baffled. “Did—we were all having the same vision in there, right? Or?”

“That’s not what she means,” said Adora, grinning. It was, admittedly, pretty fun to have all the answers for once while someone else was scrambling for clues. But there was no way she’d be able to keep this to herself, even if she wanted to.

“Holy shit,” said Mermista, face uncharacteristically expressive as she seemed to realize the truth, gaping between them. “You’re kidding.”

“Nope,” said Adora. She grinned even wider, cheeks beginning to ache. “Turns out there *is* a way I wouldn’t have picked up on it.”

“It?” echoed Catra, arching an eyebrow.

“Who you were in love with,” said Adora, softening at the reminder. Catra loved *her.* Catra had been in love with *her* for *years.* It wasn’t just a crush, it wasn’t fleeting or shallow or fake or any of the things Adora had feared in the portal, when she thought she was imposing her own desires on Catra. It was *real.*

“Seriously, did I miss something?” asked Glimmer, shrill with confusion.

“Adora was Catra’s wife in the future,” said Frosta, apparently satisfied that she’d immobilized everyone well enough to join the conversation.

“Did *you* know?” asked Bow, blinking over at her. She shrugged.

“Adora said she was the only one Catra tolerated. And their babies invented time travel.”

“What the fuck is a wife?” Lonnie asked Rogelio, barely loud enough for Adora to hear. He shook his head, grumbling

something as he continued to saw Kyle loose from the bolas.

"WHAT," said Glimmer, no longer shrill but definitely *loud.* Catra winced at Adora's side, clearly from the volume. Adora frowned, wrapping an arm around her shoulders.

"Okay," she tried, tucking the sword back in its sheath so she could gesture in supplication, "I know that—"

"WHAT?"

"Glimmer, come on," said Adora, growing embarrassed. Was it that hard to believe?

Well. It had taken her a while.

Maybe this was fair.

"How long were you—have you—were you in love with her the *whole time?"* Glimmer shrieked.

Adora groaned, hiding her face in her free hand. "... Yes."

"WH—"

"She didn't *know,"* Bow interrupted, somewhere between pleading and apologetic.

"How could she *not know?"* demanded Glimmer. She was waving her arms a lot, but there was no magic in her fists, and she didn't sound *angry,* so… maybe she was just upset she hadn't realized earlier?

"How could she not know the Horde was evil?" Bow countered, throwing his hands up to mirror hers. "It's Adora! Why would she let herself have something nice?"

"Sorry, is it *nice* to be in love with your mortal enemy?" asked Mermista, back to her unflappable self. She was visibly amused, but not quite smirking. Yet.

"It's nicer to *know* about it," said Adora, muffled by her palm. Catra laughed, dragging Adora's hand away to put her embarrassment on full display, like a jerk.

"Yeah, right. Do you have any idea what it felt like to kick your ass every other week *and* be in love with you?"

"Every other week?" Adora repeated indignantly. "Dream on. Maybe it was harder the *one* time you beat me—"

"Princess Prom."

"The *two* times you beat me—"

"Crystal clubhouse."

"The *three—"*

"And you just have *kids?"* Glimmer demanded. *"Adorable* kids?"

"The adorablest," said Catra, smugly superior in the way that always infuriated Adora during training, because it meant she *won,* and it made Adora want to—

Oh. She'd wanted to kiss her about it.

She was going to keep having these epiphanies for a while, wasn't she?

"And everyone's just *okay* with that?" asked Glimmer.

"I—well, as far as I know?" said Adora, shrugging. "They didn't like, walk me through a list of who approved or not—"

"They?" asked Perfuma. Her hands were clasped under her chin like her glee was trying to physically escape from her chest, and she had to hold it in.

"We, um," said Adora. Her eyes darted to Catra before drifting to the floor, cheeks hot under the scrutiny of two thirds of the Princess Alliance. "We don't need to get into—"

“No, hold on, who’s they?” asked Catra, leaning over so she was in Adora’s line of sight. Her eyes glittered with curiosity, a mischievous smile promising to tease it out of her one way or another.

“I—kind of—met them,” said Adora. Her face had never been this hot in her life.

“Future-you?” asked Bow. Adora groaned, hiding her face again because *no,* meeting future-Adora hadn’t been enough to clue her in, *somehow.*

“The twins,” she mumbled. Catra stilled beside her, and Adora could just make out her eyes widening from between her fingers. “As, um. Adults.”

Catra pulled away from her, sliding out from under her arm, staring at her. Adora locked eyes with her, trying to interpret the fear and trepidation she found.

Wasn’t that a good thing? Shouldn’t Catra be happy to know their children had grown up, that they’d been—

Oh.

“They were happy,” Adora whispered, too soft for anyone but Catra to hear. Her eyes welled up with tears at the thought of it, of *them,* those perfect encapsulations of some ideal future she’d never even dared to imagine. “They were so— *so* happy.”

Catra’s hands were shaking, face blank but eyes still shining with terror and disbelief.

“They loved us,” Adora murmured through a sudden lump of emotion. “They said they were *proud* of us. They know how smart you are, how— *me* I am, they—they look just like you—”

Catra folded into Adora’s arms, burying her face where no one could see, shoulders quaking too subtly for the others to notice. Adora looked up at them, the shame of her undisguised tears

forgotten in the face of that memory of the future. The princesses, Bow, her old squad—everyone was staring at them, even a gagged but still-conscious Grizzlor, who looked like he wanted to throw up.

"So let me get this straight," said Lonnie, completely ignoring a newly-freed Kyle as Rogelio helped him to his feet. "Scorpia told us Catra showed up from the future with a baby. Adora showed up from the future with a second baby. *Nobody* thought that might be significant?"

"I mean, I assumed it would have *come up!"* said Glimmer, with a hurt and indignant semi-glare at Adora.

"Don't look at me!" she protested. "They didn't tell me either!"

"They shouldn't have *had to,* Adora!" snapped Lonnie. "You were top of our year in recon and you're telling me you couldn't recognize your own fucking kids?"

"I didn't know I *had* kids!" said Adora, flushing with embarrassment.

"Who else would Catra shack up with?" yelled Lonnie, with a disgusted arm wave that seemed to encompass the whole of their relationship. "And why wouldn't *they* have come to get her?"

"Whatl—of course I would be the one to come get her! Even if we weren't—"

"You didn't think the other parent would have wanted to tag along while future-you brought their remaining infant through a magic mystery hole?"

Adora flushed darker. It had just made so much *sense* that future-Adora had shown up—it never occurred to her that it was weird future—Adora had Adam *with* her. She'd been thinking of them as *Catra's* kittens, so in her mind it was perfectly logical that Adora would be the one looking after him, searching for his mother. And

yeah, she'd wondered where their other mom was, but she'd been so distracted…

Catra's hypothetical future-wife had just been an accessory to Catra, a method by which the kittens came into existence. Now, knowing that *she* was that future-wife, Adora couldn't believe it had taken so long for her to consider what the experience would have looked like from the other side.

If she and Catra had children, and Catra disappeared through a spontaneous magic portal with one of them? Adora would lose her *mind* looking for them. There was no reality in which she would give Adam to someone else, even a 'best friend', *especially* if that friend was going to be conducting magical experiments with him.

Her defense against Lonnie died in her throat as the thought fully registered.

"I—I gave a *magic sword* to our *son* ," said Adora, turning to Catra, eyes wide with horror. "And I didn't even know it would *work."*

Catra snickered, patting her on the shoulder as if consoling her after losing a race, not absolving her of *arming* their *infant.* "Yeah, and as I recall you already got chewed out for it. That was old-Adora's fault anyway."

"But that was *so* irresponsible!" she insisted. If she ever saw future-Adora again, she was going to give her a piece of her mind. "It was bad enough when I thought they were just regular magic babies, what if they got some of my powers?"

"Adora, I hate to break it to you, but they *did,* or none of this shit would be happening."

"I mean, like—the transforming! And the rainbow beam punching stuff! What if he'd turned into some huge warrior guy while I was holding him and I *dropped* him?"

"Adora—"

"What if he did that thing that turned Swift Wind into Swift Wind and he hit me and I was just like, a unicorn forever?" she went on, growing more frantic. "I don't even know how half my powers *work,* how could I—?"

"Adora, it'd been ten years," Catra interrupted, laughing at her. "You *probably* learned a thing or two about your powers in the meantime. And he was fine anyway, so maybe you should stop freaking out about a hypothetical disaster that *could* have happened in an *alternate universe* and start freaking out about all the *actual* disasters we're going to have to clean up here and now."

Adora stared at her with wide, wild eyes, then gasped, whipping her head around. "Entrapta!"

"Yes?" asked Entrapta, looking up from where she was bent over Hordak and the ruins of the portal machine, blinking up at Adora.

"We need to start brainstorming ways to track people through time, *now."*

Entrapta blinked again, gaze drifting over the destroyed sanctum, the unconscious Hordak, the twisted wreckage of her last experiment. A smile spread across her face.

"Okay, no," Catra cut in, before she could agree. "We're focusing on rebuilding, not magic-baby-proofing for kids you're just *assuming* we'll have."

Adora opened her mouth to argue, but cut herself off, blushing furiously, as that registered. "Sorry," she mumbled, "that was pretty um. Presumptive."

"You don't say," said Catra, distinctly unimpressed.

"Like *you* have any right to talk about presumption," sniped Glimmer. Catra rose to the bait immediately, letting Adora stew in her mortification unobserved for a moment.

She rubbed the back of her neck, looking out over the mess they'd left of Hordak's sanctum. She'd just been barrelling down the path that had been laid out for her by other people, *again.* It was like muscle memory at this point, and once again she'd tried to drag Catra along with her. Did Catra even *want* kids? Did *Adora?*

She couldn't remember ever giving it serious thought before all the time travel stuff. It had just seemed like a given that she wouldn't have any. Children weren't exactly forbidden in the Horde; you got time off for incubation and recovery, and contact between parent and child was still allowed, if socially discouraged. But a soldier's first priority had to be the Horde. In most cases she'd heard of, parents had disavowed their children to prevent weakness from festering in either party.

As a cadet, she'd applauded their pragmatism. Producing more soldiers for the cause, and forestalling the exploitation that personal attachments so often led to by severing the connection at the root. She used to pretend her own parents had been Horde soldiers, that she'd been born of warrior stock and they had surrendered her joyfully to the Horde's embrace, knowing she would be protected and raised to value the stability and order they fought for.

Shadow Weaver had dispelled that fantasy with the truth (however small a piece of it) early on, leaving Adora to wonder, and wonder, and wonder.

Now she wondered only how many Horde-born recruits had been surrendered *willingly.* Certainly she hadn't accounted for the inherent coercion, the threat of manipulation imposed by caring so openly for something so helpless.

Was there any atrocity she herself would be unwilling to commit, if Hordak were watching, with the twins' lives in his hands? She would do anything for them. She would have razed a thousand Thaymors.

And it would have destroyed her.

None of that had been a conscious thought, but she realized now she'd been implicitly aware of the danger in caring for a child. Simply caring for her peers had already brought so much pain and heartache. It had been a simple calculation: Better to improve herself, her dedication to the Horde, than to waste months off the field to produce more soldiers. Quality over quantity.

And when she'd left…

Since the moment she'd become She-Ra, a sense of impending doom had gathered around her like a thundercloud. There hadn't been *time.* Cyra was right—even seeing proof of her survival with her own two eyes, part of Adora had been convinced she would die for the cause. Part of her still was. There was no piece of herself she was unwilling to give up for a chance to end the war, no dream or desire she wouldn't crush with her own two hands if it stood in the way of Etheria's freedom.

If she couldn't have kids in the Horde because they'd be used against her, she couldn't have kids in the Rebellion because *she'd* be used against *them.*

But now, here she was, healthy and happy and *free,* the Horde's defeat all but cemented, and the possibilities were all she could think about. The future yawned before her like a sky full of stars, half-remembered in the moments between sleep and wakefulness, visions revealed in flashes of magic.

It didn't matter, she decided, taking Catra's hand in hers. It didn't matter if they had kids in some distant future. This was already so much more than she ever could have imagined, and Catra was right—she needed to focus on the here and now. To savor the shock and joy and love overwhelming her with each new moment, thrumming through her veins with every pulse of her heart.

Catra was still bickering with Glimmer, but it was a constructive kind of bickering. Working together to pick apart potential

downsides of whatever plan they were concocting.

Bow was trying to thaw out some of the Horde officers, talking to Kyle with a slightly strained smile as Lonnie and Rogelio argued about something beside them.

The princesses were crowded around Scorpia, debating the pros and cons of connecting her to the Black Garnet while Entrapta wheedled for a chance to experiment on it again instead, Hordak's imp wriggling unhappily in her arms.

Nobody needed Adora for anything, but for once that felt like a relief instead of a death sentence. Catra had wound their fingers together, and Glimmer kept giving her exasperated 'can you *believe* this' looks, both of them acknowledging her, including her, even if she wasn't even pretending to pay attention to their conversation.

They didn't need her, but they wanted her here, with them.

Logistically, the next few months—years?—were going to be a nightmare. Adora didn't even know where they were going to start, how they could possibly address decades of military occupation in anything resembling an organized fashion. They had to teach the Horde soldiers how to be civilians, had to integrate them into a society they'd need to first convince to accept them. They had to figure out where to *keep* everyone while they were being taught burning and pillaging were wrong. They had to build some kind of infrastructure to support Horde soldiers and refugees alike, to produce and distribute resources to people without just stealing things back and forth from each other constantly. They had to disassemble the Fright Zone mining and harvesting machinery, to mitigate the damage already done to Etheria and see what could be mended, magically or otherwise.

Maybe She-Ra would be healing the land after all.

Even aside from reconstructing the basic foundations of society, there were all the interpersonal hurdles. They had to learn how to

communicate, how to voice insecurities and hurts, how to listen when others did the same. Honestly, that scared Adora a lot more.

She squeezed Catra's hand, drawing her attention for a moment. Catra smiled at her, not exactly *shy* but certainly more vulnerable than Adora was expecting, and her heart squeezed in her chest.

They were a mess, together and individually—the whole world was a mess. But they were together now. Adora could take on anything the future could throw at her, with Catra and their friends at her side.

Nothing was perfect, and she wouldn't have it any other way.

Chapter End Notes

> thank you all for joining me on this self-indulgent little journey. it won't be the last you hear from me by any means, but we're now officially bidding this alternate timeline farewell. i have some ideas about how it ultimately pans out but i'm not interested in writing them bc other, shinier ideas have since caught mine eye. 2 of them even make use of the unhealthy amount of research i've done, which like, you gotta see how that's more tempting for me than 'rogelio learns ethics'. hm. okay now that i wrote it out that sounds kind of baller but no, no. the opportunity to infodump still wins, i'm sorry.
>
> as always, you can find me on my tumblr, or my sideblog, which is she-ra specific but has recently been focusing on early brand history bc none of that shit's available online & i think it's v v v important to preserve it and make it accessible to people. i recently acquired a no good very bad *officially licensed book* which got all its She-Ra info from Wiki Grayskull & did not so much as mention the people who came up with the toys. it sucks! and yeah maybe this author was just phoning it in on the She-Ra section bc he didn't care about She-Ra, but the fact that he can disseminate such easily identifiable misinformation (in addition to making me

feel like i'm going insane) is a sign that there is not enough concrete history available to people, even if they want to look. How should a casual fan know not to trust Wiki Grayskull? Or a licensed fucking book?

i've gone on a tangent now, sorry. well. i'll get back to the screenshot cataloguing at some point. none of my fic stuff is up there except the outfit design i did, i wanted to keep it focused on the show/brand & not my personal content. that said, if you want any additional info for this series, there's still some fun sketches & such up in my For Having Wept in the Darkness tag, & my ask box is always open.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!